

QMX+ Panadapter — User Guide (v1.7.0)

By Steffen Lav (OZ1LAV). Generated from the project README — for the live page, issues, and releases see <https://github.com/SteffenLav/qmx-panadapter>

The full documentation also lives online at tab5.lav.dk — the user guide, quick-start, and reference as searchable, cross-linked web pages, kept in sync with every release.

Features

Everything below is in the firmware **today**. Nothing here needs a PC, and only the items marked (*needs WiFi*) need a network.

Real-time panadapter — Spectrum and waterfall across a 48 kHz window centred on the QMX VFO, at 30 Hz, with 12 kHz IF-offset compensation. Tap or drag to tune (mode-aware snapping), pinch to zoom $\times 1$ – $\times 24$ with a true zoom-FFT, one-finger drag to pan and retune. Adaptive per-bin noise floor, flat-spectrum mode, adjustable waterfall black level and contrast, selectable FFT window, and a graphical S-meter calibrated in dBm. A colour band-plan strip tracks the VFO (IARU region 1/2/3, auto-selected from your grid) and can be dragged to scrub across the band.

QMX CAT control — Live frequency, mode (USB/LSB/CW/DiGi, plus AM on QMX firmware 1.04+), SSB filter bandwidth, CW passband, passband overlay, TX power and SWR readout, QMX volume in decibels matching the radio's own display, and an Antenna Tune button on 1.04+. Round-trip CAT latency under 50 ms. Band presets with per-band frequency recall, and 32 memory channels in a 4 $\times$ 8 grid holding any frequency and mode.

FT8 and FT4, receive — Continuous on-device decoding in the same view as the panadapter: FT8 (15 s slots) and FT4 (7.5 s slots). The decode list shows callsign, country, signal report, slot-timing offset (DT), audio tone (HZ), distance and bearing, with the station you are working held at the top. Include/exclude filters match anything in the message text, worked-before stations can be excluded band-by-band, and a pileup tracker collects everyone calling you.

FT8 and FT4, transmit — Tap a station and the correct *next* message is sent (WSJT-X double-click style); or call CQ from one of three editable presets, with an optional stop-after-N-calls limit. Full automatic exchange through to 73 and an ADIF entry, a resend if your partner never heard your final, a polite hold for a station already working someone else, grey-listing for stations that never answer, and an optional unattended auto-answer robot. Your TX tone is a permanent on-screen button with a live occupancy strip, drag-to-pick tone selection, **TX Hold**, and a cycling **TXCQ ANY / EVEN / ODD** time-window choice. ARRL Field Day exchange mode included.

QSO logging and upload — Every contact is written to an ADIF log on the device, with timestamp, callsign, grid, frequency, band, mode, both signal reports and distance (never a report that was not actually exchanged). Read the log on the Tab5 or in the browser, delete single records or all of them, and upload (*needs WiFi*) to **QRZ Logbook**, **eQSL** and **ARRL LoTW** — LoTW QSOs are signed on the device itself with your own callsign certificate.

Live spots on the spectrum (*needs WiFi*) — **POTA** park activations, and optionally **RBN** CW skimmer spots and **DX cluster** spots, drawn onto the trace at the frequency the station is actually using. The cluster is where phone activity comes from — skimmers are machines, and no machine recognises a callsign spoken into a microphone. One station is one entry, however many sources report it. Grey means you have already worked them on that band. Press and drag to pick one, lift to tune it *with the right mode*. Spots fade with age and are gone after 30 minutes; corner counts take you to the ones just off-screen.

Knowing you are getting out (*needs WiFi*) — **Who is hearing me** asks PSK Reporter which receivers have copied *your* call, with distance, bearing and the report they gave you. **SWR protection** cuts a transmission short and latches the transmitter off above your chosen limit, because an FT8 burst is thirteen seconds of key-down into whatever the antenna is doing.

Activation logging — Start a **POTA** or **SOTA** activation and every contact is stamped with the reference as it is logged, counted against the threshold, with chases tagged from spots already seen and a single-reference ADIF export for uploading.

Bluetooth mouse — A pointer that works *while the QMX stays plugged in*, which a USB mouse cannot do on this hardware. Pair once; it reconnects by itself. Move, click, and a wheel that scrolls whatever is under the pointer.

PSK Reporter spotting (*needs WiFi*) — The stations you decode are reported to [PSK Reporter](#) the way WSJT-X does, so you appear on the map as a monitoring station. **On by default**; sends your call and grid plus each decoded station's call, grid, frequency, report and mode, batched at most once every five minutes — over the internet only, **never on the air**. One checkbox turns it off, and it is inert until your callsign and grid are set, and in simulation mode.

Web UI (*needs WiFi*) — The whole panadapter in any browser on the LAN: live spectrum and waterfall at ~10 fps, click or drag to tune, mouse-wheel pan and tune, band/mode/bandwidth/zoom control, a graphical S-meter and the whole-band plan strip. In FT8/FT4 mode it shows a live TX status banner and a **Call CQ** button instead of the stream. Also: the QSO log as a sortable table, config download/upload as an editable text file, a microSD file browser, screenshots, and the diagnostic log.

Built-in user manual — This entire guide is compiled into the firmware, so it opens instantly with no WiFi, no card and no download, and can never describe a different version than the one you are running. It opens at the chapter for the screen you are on, warning banners are tappable, and a **Need guidance?** panel lets you pick your symptom in plain words. See [Getting help](#).

Time, with or without a network — SNTP when WiFi is up (*needs WiFi*), the Tab5's own supercap-backed RTC across power-off, the QMX's clock as an offline fallback, GPS detected and phase-locked automatically if your QMX has one, and a manual set-and-sync panel. FT8/FT4 timing also self-corrects from the decoded band consensus when offline.

microSD station backup — Insert a card (a plain FAT32 32 GB card is ideal) **before switching on** and your whole station is mirrored to `/qmx-panadapter/`: the ADIF log, a full config export, your LoTW certificate and key, the diagnostic log and a self-describing `README.txt`. Continuous with WiFi off (green **SD** dot); one complete backup per start-up with WiFi on (yellow dot), because the card and the WiFi co-processor share a bus. (*The card holds credentials — WiFi password, QRZ/eQSL logins, LoTW private key — so keep it physically secure.*)

Diagnostics — An always-on diagnostic log, nothing to enable: 5 MB in RAM, a rolling copy in flash that survives a power cut, and a full mirror to microSD if a card is in. Downloadable from the browser or over USB serial. Bug reports become answerable.

Practice mode — A simulator with phantom stations that call CQ and reply through the real encode/decode pipeline, so you can rehearse a full QSO with **no radio connected** — and with a hard interlock that never keys a QMX even if one is attached.

Touch, keyboard, mouse — Edge-swipe navigation with breathing grip handles, an on-screen keyboard, optional support for the M5Stack Tab5 70-key snap-on keyboard, and USB mouse support. (*The mouse and the QMX cannot share the single USB host port — the ESP32-P4's USB stack lacks the Transaction Translator a hub would need — so the mouse is for setup, log review and reading the manual with the radio unplugged.*)

Built for the field — WiFi is entirely optional; battery percentage and voltage with a charge limit for battery care; display sleep and a 180° flip for awkward mounting; config backup and restore as a text file; and a settings reset that does not need a reflash.

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1. Quick Guide

Step 0 — Check your QMX firmware first

Power the QMX on by itself and read the firmware version off its own display at boot. You need **1.03.002 or newer**. If yours is older, update the QMX *before* connecting the Tab5 — everything that follows depends on it. This takes 10 seconds to verify and saves hours of debugging. Both **1.03.002** and the **1.04 betas** work with the panadapter (1.04.004 is what this is developed against day to day); on 1.04 the Tab5 additionally offers **AM mode** and an **Antenna Tune** button (SWR tune with a live power/SWR readout) — both stay hidden on 1.03.002, so there's no downside either way.

Step 1 — Flash the Tab5 firmware

Use the one-click flasher in [tools/QMX-Panadapter flasher/](#) (also attached to each [release](#)):

1. Plug the Tab5 into your computer with a **USB-C data cable** — charge-only cables will not work.
2. Run the flasher:
 - **Windows** — double-click `flash.bat` (fetches esptool by itself on first run; nothing to install)
 - **macOS** — double-click `flash.command` (needs esptool once — `brew install esptool` recommended; `pip3 install esptool` often fails on recent macOS with an "externally-managed-environment" error). If macOS blocks the script, right-click → **Open**, or run `bash flash.command` in Terminal (no `chmod` needed).
 - **Linux** — `bash flash.command` (needs `pip3 install esptool`)
3. The flasher asks **normal or clean** (see below) — just press **Enter** for a normal flash.
4. Wait for **success**. The Tab5 restarts on the new firmware.

The firmware is already in the zip — `bootloader.bin`, `partition-table.bin` and `qmx_panadapter.bin` sit next to the script, and those are what get flashed. Nothing is downloaded except `esptool` itself, once, if your computer doesn't already have it. So after the first successful run the flasher works with no internet at all.

Normal vs clean flash. Just before flashing, the flasher asks:

Type E for a CLEAN/ERASE flash, or just Enter for a normal flash

- **Normal (press Enter)** — updates the firmware and **keeps** all your saved settings (WiFi, callsign, grid, memory channels, ADIF log). This is what you want almost every time.
- **Clean (type E)** — wipes the whole chip first, so **every saved setting is permanently erased**: WiFi name *and* password, callsign/grid, all memory channels, and the logged QSOs. Use it only if something is stuck or corrupted (e.g. WiFi refuses to turn on no matter what). Back up first with **Config** ↓ (below) so you can restore in seconds afterwards.

Building from source? See [Build from source](#).

Step 2 — Connect the cables

You need **two** USB connections, and the cable to the QMX is the one people get wrong:

Connection	Port on Tab5	Cable	Carries
Tab5 → QMX	USB-A (host)	USB-A → USB-C, full data cable	I/Q audio (UAC) + CAT (CDC-ACM)
Tab5 → power	USB-C	Any USB-C power cable (5 V / 2 A+)	Power

The #1 failure is a charge-only cable. Many USB-C cables — especially thin ones bundled with phones and chargers — carry power only, no data lines. If you use one between the Tab5's USB-A port and the QMX, the Tab5 powers the QMX but sees no audio and no CAT: the spectrum stays flat and the top bar shows Band: ---. Use a cable you know does data (one that works for a USB stick or phone file transfer). When in doubt, swap the cable first.

Power-on order matters. Turn the **Tab5 on first** and let it finish loading, then turn the **QMX on**. Within a few seconds the top bar should populate Band / Mode / BW and the spectrum should come alive.

Once flashed you can power the Tab5 from any 5 V/2 A USB-C source or the internal battery — the laptop is only needed for flashing. For diagnostics the Tab5 also outputs a serial log over the USB-C data connection (useful if WiFi is not available), but for most users the built-in **diagnostic log** — always on, nothing to enable — is the easier path — see [Step 7](#).

Step 3 — Find your way around

The whole app is driven by **one-finger swipes from the screen edges** and **taps on the top bar**. The settings drawer is always one swipe away — no hunting for hidden menus.

Gesture	From	Does
Swipe →	Left edge	Toggle Panadapter ↔ FT8 screen
Swipe ←	Right edge	Open settings drawer
Swipe ↑	Bottom edge	Open memory channel picker
Tap or swipe ↓	Any top-bar item	Open that item's selector

Slim "breathing" grip handles on each edge show where to swipe — faint enough not to clutter the display, visible if you look for them.

The top bar reads **Band · Mode · BW · Freq · Signal · Zoom** left to right. Tap any item to open a selector — **Freq** opens the frequency keypad; **Mode** switches USB/LSB/CW/DiGi; **BW** selects SSB filter width (USB/LSB only); **Band** jumps to a configured band; **Zoom** selects a zoom preset.

See the [full gesture table](#) in the Reference section.

Step 3b — Choose FT8 or FT4 mode

FT8 is available on all HF bands; FT4 is available on select bands with published frequencies (20 m, 30 m, 40 m, etc.). To switch between them:

1. **In Panadapter mode:** Tap the **Mode** selector in the top bar, then choose **DiGi** (the digital mode group).
2. **In FT8 screen:** Tap the **Preset** frequency button to open the band/mode picker — you'll see **two columns**: FT8 (gold header) on the left, FT4 (cyan header) on the right. Tap any frequency in the FT4 column to switch modes.

The decode list, TX controls, and slot timing (countdown bar, which-parity-next) all adapt automatically to the active mode. Switching modes clears stale decodes from the previous mode so you don't work old QSOs.

When to use each mode:

- **FT8** — Most populated band in SOTA/POTA; longer decode window gives more time to prepare replies on slow links or weak signals.

- **FT4** — Faster QSO cycle for busy bands (Field Day, major contests, 20 m pile-ups) and operators who prefer shorter waits between exchanges.

Step 4 — Fill in your settings

On first boot the Tab5 opens a setup prompt automatically — it will ask for your callsign, grid square, and WiFi credentials before you reach the main screen. You can skip any field and fill it in later via the settings drawer.

To open the settings drawer at any time: swipe in from the right edge, or tap the right grip handle.

- **WiFi** — enter your SSID and password. Recommended for everyone: you get accurate UTC time (needed for FT8 slot timing), the browser web UI, and remote diagnostics. The **WiFi initiated** checkbox below the WiFi section is an on/off master switch — uncheck it for POTA or field use with no network.
- **Identity** (callsign + grid square) — *only required for FT8/FT4 transmit*. Enter your callsign and Maidenhead grid (4 or 6 characters, e.g. J045 or J045ab). The grid also drives the distance and bearing columns in the FT8 decode list.

Everything else — dB range, smoothing, colour map, brightness, IQ balance — has sane defaults. Adjust if you want to, but you don't need to on first use.

Step 5 — Using the panadapter

Switch the QMX to any band and watch it come alive. This is the foundation of the device regardless of which modes you operate.

Tap or drag to tune. Touch anywhere on the spectrum or waterfall to place the cyan cursor. Drag and it snaps to a mode-aware grid — 10 Hz steps in CW, 250 Hz in SSB, 500 Hz for FT8/FT4 — so you can land precisely on a signal before lifting your finger. Lift, and the QMX retunes.

Swipe fast to pan instead. A quick horizontal swipe (rather than a held drag) slides the whole view left or right and retunes to wherever you let go — the fastest way to slide along a band. See [Touch-to-tune](#) for exactly how the two gestures are told apart.

Or move precisely with the band-plan slider. For a controlled move rather than a quick swipe, drag the framed "visible window" on the band-plan strip (along the bottom) to exactly where you want to be on the band — the spectrum, waterfall, and VFO all follow it, so you can place yourself precisely on a segment before you even tap a signal.

Zoom in on a crowded band. Pinch with two fingers to zoom up to $\times 24$. On a CW band at $\times 8$ or higher you can resolve individual signals a few hundred Hz apart, read the spacing between callers, and pick your target before you tune. The frequency axis scales with you, down to Hz precision at high zoom. Double-tap anywhere to reset to the full 48 kHz view.

Find your place on the band. The thin band-plan strip along the bottom of the screen (just above the status bar) colour-codes the CW/Digi/Phone segments around you — pick your IARU region (or leave it on Auto) in the settings drawer → **Band-plan region**. The framed window on the strip is a **slider**: drag it (or tap anywhere on the strip) to move precisely to any spot on the band, and the spectrum, waterfall and VFO all follow along. You can also grab that slider from anywhere along the bottom status bar and drag sideways — a taller target — while a vertical up-swipe there still opens memory channels.

Read your passband. Two grey vertical lines on the spectrum mark your current filter edges. The BW label in the top bar shows the active width; tap it to choose 2.5 / 2.7 / 2.9 / 3.2 kHz in USB or LSB. A coloured tint fills the passband so you can always see exactly what slice of the band you're receiving.

Watch the S-meter. The Signal field in the top bar is a live tick-scale bar (S1 through S9+20), driven by the actual signal under your VFO cursor.

Flat-spectrum mode. Toggle **Flat spectrum** in the settings drawer to switch from absolute dBm to dB-above-local-noise-floor. Noise collapses to a calm baseline; real signals — including weak CW tones in the mud — pop sharply above it. Recommended on noisy bands.

Save your spots. Swipe up from the bottom edge to open the memory channel picker — a 4×8 grid of 32 channels. It doesn't greet you with blank cells: a fresh device arrives with a handful of **example channels already filled in**, and each one is **colour-coded by mode** (CW green, DiGi teal, USB brick-red, LSB purple) so you can read the whole grid at a glance without opening a single label. The very first time you open it, a quick **guided animation** walks you through the gestures — watch a channel slide to a new slot, then drop into the wastebin and vanish — so you learn "drag to move, drag to delete" in about ten seconds, once, and never again.

Then it's yours: **tap** a channel to recall it (the QMX retunes instantly), **tap an empty slot** to store the current frequency/mode, **long-press** to edit, **drag** a channel to reorganise the grid, and **drag onto the wastebin** (bottom-right cell) to delete it.

Monitor from another room — or operate remotely. Once WiFi is configured, open `http://<tab5-ip>` in any browser for a full-featured live panadapter with mouse-driven tuning, band/mode controls, and ADIF log download. The IP is shown in the bottom status bar. See [Web UI](#).

Step 6 — FT8 (if that's your thing)

Swipe in from the **left edge** to switch to the FT8 screen. The Tab5 starts decoding 15-second slots immediately — no PC, no WSJT-X required.

1. Tap the **Preset** button and pick your band's conventional FT8 dial frequency (e.g. 14.074 MHz for 20 m).
2. Watch the decode list fill. CQ stations appear at the top sorted by SNR; exchanges and replies below.
3. To reply to a station: **hold your finger on their row** for ~250 ms. A dim highlight appears after ~80 ms so you can see which row you're targeting before the gate fires. Lift — a confirmation modal shows the exact message before anything is armed.
4. Tap **Auto Pounce** to hand the full QSO to the auto-engine (works through report → RR73 → 73 with patient retry), or **Transmit** for a single manual message.
5. To call CQ: tap **Call CQ**. The engine picks a clear audio slot, fires CQ, automatically answers the first caller, runs the full exchange, logs the QSO, and resumes calling CQ.

Every completed QSO is written to an ADIF log downloadable from the web UI. See [FT8 Transmit](#) for the full picture, including ARRL Field Day exchange mode and a no-radio-keyed practice/simulation mode.

Step 7 — Something not working?

Spectrum flat, top bar shows ---:

- Check the cable between Tab5 and QMX — almost always a charge-only cable.
- Make sure the QMX is powered on and not stuck in its own bootloader.
- Power cycle in order: Tab5 first, then QMX.

For anything else:

1. The diagnostic log is **always on** — nothing to enable.
2. Reproduce the problem (let it run a minute; power-cycle the QMX if the issue is about connection).

3. Grab the log:

- **Over WiFi:** in the web UI take **Files ▲** → **Diagnostic download ↓**. That one item fetches **both** logs — `qmx-log.txt`, the current session held in RAM, and `qmx-log-saved.txt`, the copy persisted to flash that survives a reboot or a flat battery. If the device restarted, the saved one is the interesting file. (Directly: `/api/log` and `/api/log/saved`.)
- **microSD:** if a card is inserted, the log is mirrored to `/qmx-panadapter/qmx-log.txt` on the card — continuously with WiFi off, or up to the start-up backup with WiFi on (alongside the always-on flash-persisted copy, which is complete either way).
- **Over USB (no WiFi needed):** capture the serial console with `tools/capture_serial_log.ps1`.

4. Open an [issue](#) and attach the log. It includes Tab5 and QMX firmware versions plus every CAT command exchanged — usually enough to pinpoint the problem immediately.

Getting help

This whole guide is inside the firmware. No WiFi, no microSD card, no download: it works on the first boot, in a field with no signal, and it can never describe a different version than the one you are running. Swipe ← from the right edge to open the settings drawer; the top two buttons are the two ways in.

User Manual — opens where you are. Not a contents page to search: it opens the chapter covering the screen you were on — the panadapter chapter, the FT8 **receive** chapter, or the FT8 **transmit** chapter if a transmission is armed or running (someone mid-transmission is asking a different question). Inside: **Contents** is a two-column list — press and slide, and lifting your finger opens the highlighted chapter; **Back** returns to the previous page (shown only when there is one); **Exit** puts you back where you came from. Edge swipes and top-bar taps are stood down while the manual is open, so a stray touch cannot retune behind it. Holding the **User Manual** button for 3 s resets the reader; the manual itself is part of the firmware and cannot be lost.

Need guidance? — describe the symptom, not the cause. The second drawer button opens a short list headed "*What do you need help with?*", written the way you would say it out loud — "My radio is not showing up", "Nothing appears in the decode list", "It never transmits", "How do I change what my CQ says?", "Where are my contacts logged?" Pick the one that fits and the manual opens at the section that answers it. The list holds questions as well as faults, and it scrolls — keep going past the first few rows.

Rows the Tab5 can see are happening now are highlighted and floated to the top: no CAT link to the QMX, IQ mode never confirmed, an empty decode list while FT8 is running with the radio present, or WiFi switched on but not connected. WiFi switched **off** deliberately — POTA, battery — is not reported as a fault; that row stays as a normal question. **The device ranks, you choose:** a highlighted row is a suggestion, and it will never navigate for you on inference. The rows offered are scoped to the screen you opened the panel from, so FT8 never offers you spectrum symptoms.

Warnings you can tap. A warning you cannot act on is half a warning. The red "**QMX IQ mode not confirmed**" banner across the top of the screen is a button — tap it for the section on that exact fault. The "**Waiting for QMX**" message carries a small **Need help?** button; it says *help* rather than *what is wrong* on purpose, since a radio that is off is often off deliberately.

If a chapter does not answer your question, that is a documentation bug worth reporting — the wording of these rows is written from what operators actually say.

2. Panadapter

The panadapter is your primary view — a real-time spectrum analyser and waterfall for the QMX.

2.1. Layout

```
type: stack
title: The panadapter screen, top to bottom
row: 60 Top bar | frequency, mode, filter width, S-meter, zoom
row: 200 Spectrum | green trace, amber VFO cursor, tinted passband
row: 32 Frequency axis | absolute MHz labels
row: 370 Waterfall | newest row at the top, SDR gradient
row: 22 Band-plan strip | CW / Digi / Phone segments, with the visible span marked
row: 36 Status bar | battery, UTC clock, WiFi
note: amber | the VFO cursor sits at the dial frequency; in USB the passband tint runs
note: dim | the top-right 200 x 120 of the spectrum is a deadzone, so a tap near the d
```



Status bar indicators:

Left to right: battery, the SD dot, the firmware version, the UTC clock, and the WiFi indicator with the network name and IP address.

Item	Meaning
Battery % and voltage	Charge level, with the measured pack voltage beside it (e.g. 88% (8.1V))
SD (green dot)	A microSD card is mounted and being mirrored continuously — the case with WiFi off (see Settings)
SD (yellow dot)	A card is present and your start-up backup is written, but continuous mirroring has stopped — the case with WiFi on. Your log, config and LoTW certificate are safe on the card; later QSOs are written at the next start-up
UTC(GPS) / UTC(NTP) / UTC(FT8) / UTC(FT4)	The time source currently in charge — GPS-disciplined QMX, WiFi/SNTP, or FT8/FT4 offline sync (RTC / manual show as UTC(RTC) / UTC(MAN))
Firmware version	Currently flashed firmware version
WiFi fan icon	Link strength, at the right-hand end with the network name and IP address. The dot alone means a weak link (above 25 %), plus the first bow above 50 %, plus the second above 80 %; all three faint means connected but very weak, or off. From v1.3.4 this replaces the old -NN dBm figure — the width went to the network name, which is far more often too long to fit

2.2. Touch Controls

Tap to Tune

Tap anywhere on the spectrum or waterfall to jump to that frequency. The tap snaps to a frequency grid so you land on a sensible frequency rather than wherever your fingertip happened to be.

Callsigns from [Live Spots](#) are drawn over the spectrum and are the one exception: tapping a **callsign** tunes to that station and sets the mode, rather than tuning to the point you touched.

The snap step follows the **mode**, not the zoom level — a CW signal needs to be found to the hertz, an FT8 dial frequency does not:

Mode	Snap step
CW / CW-R	10 Hz
USB / LSB	250 Hz
DiGi / FT8 / FT4 / RTTY	500 Hz
AM / FM	1 kHz

The grid is anchored to absolute frequency, not to where your finger first touched, so the cursor always lands on the same set of points no matter where the drag began.

Pinch to Zoom

Use two fingers to pinch in (zoom out) or pinch out (zoom in). The display centers on the passband width — in USB/LSB modes, the passband center stays on screen even when the VFO is off to the side.

Pan (One-Finger Drag)

Drag horizontally with one finger to scroll the spectrum left/right. Release to tune to the new center frequency.

Band-Plan Strip

Along the bottom of the screen — just above the status bar, below the waterfall — is a thin coloured strip showing where you are within the band at a glance. Each colour zone marks the conventional segment (CW, Digi, Phone) for your selected region (auto / ITU Region 1/2/3, set in settings).

The **visible-span block** inside the strip shows the exact portion of the band the spectrum and waterfall are currently displaying — it narrows as you zoom in and shifts as you pan.

A **passband sub-block** inside the visible-span block mirrors the current filter width at band scale (grey tint), so you can see how your passband sits within the CW/Digi/Phone zones.

Tune directly from the strip:

- **Tap** anywhere on the strip to jump to that frequency
- **Drag** to scrub along the band — the frequency label updates live and the QMX retunes on release

Drag from the bottom bar too. The visible-span block acts as a slider handle that reaches *below* the thin strip: touch on or just under it — anywhere along the bottom status bar — and **drag sideways** to scrub the band, exactly like dragging the strip itself. This gives you a much taller grab target. It coexists with the memory-picker gesture on the same row: a **sideways** drag retunes the band-plan, while a **vertical up-swipe** still opens the memory picker.

The strip updates live as you zoom, pan, or change bands.

Memory Channels

Swipe ↑ from the bottom edge to open the memory picker — a 4×8 grid of 32 channels, each free to hold any frequency/mode (not tied to a band). Each channel stores:

- Frequency
- Mode (USB, LSB, CW, DiGi)
- Label (your own name for the channel)

Each button shows the mode colour (CW = green, DiGi = teal, USB = brick red, LSB = purple) so you can tell mode at a glance without reading the label.

Recall: Tap a filled channel to immediately retune to it.

Tap an empty slot to create a new channel there directly — the frequency keypad opens straight away.

Long-press + drag a filled channel to move it to a different empty slot — no editing needed, the data follows your finger. Release on an empty slot to drop.

Long-press in place to open the editor (change name, frequency, or mode).

Entering a frequency outside the legal amateur band edges is rejected immediately with an error — the pad stays open so you can correct it without starting over.

2.3. Top Bar

Tap any item to open its selector:

Item	Purpose
14.074	Frequency. Tap to open the frequency keypad.
USB	Mode. Tap to open the picker: USB, LSB, CW, DiGi — plus AM once the connected QMX reports 1.04 or newer firmware.
2.5 kHz	Bandwidth (SSB only). Tap to choose 2.5, 2.7, 2.9, or 3.2 kHz.
S7	S-meter. Shows received signal strength. Display only — there is nothing to tap.
1.0x	Zoom level. Tap to choose x1, x2, x4, x8, x16 or x24. Pinching sets any value in between.

2.4. Spectrum & Waterfall

The **spectrum** shows real-time signal strength (green curve) across the tuned band. The **waterfall** shows a rolling history of that spectrum, with colour indicating signal strength (SDR gradient: blue → green → yellow → red).

Flat Spectrum Mode (in settings) shows the dB scale relative to a per-bin noise floor, so even weak signals pop above the baseline. Normal mode shows absolute dBm (referenced to a -73 dBm S9 mark).

Waterfall Controls (in settings):

- **Black level** — how far above noise-floor to go black (default 9 dB)
- **Contrast** — dB span of the colour ramp (default 45 dB)
- **Adaptive floor** — blend between per-bin and global noise floor (default 100%)
- **FFT window** — Blackman-Harris, Hann, or Nuttall (default Blackman-Harris)

2.5. Display & Buffer Features

Spectrum Buffer Clear

When you **switch modes** (Panadapter ↔ FT8 ↔ FT4) or **change bands**, the panadapter automatically **clears the waterfall and resets the spectrum baseline**. This prevents stale signals from interfering with your new band or mode view.

- Waterfall clears completely (starts fresh)
- Noise floor recalibrates
- New baseline takes ~1 second to establish

This happens transparently — you'll notice the waterfall momentarily clear and re-initialize, then populate with real-time data from the new band/mode.

Flat Spectrum Mode

Toggle in settings. Shows dB scale relative to a **per-bin noise floor** (not absolute dBm), so weak signals stand out above the baseline even on a noisy band.

- **Normal mode:** absolute dBm referenced to S9 = -73 dBm
- **Flat mode:** relative dB above each bin's noise floor

2.6. Frequency Keypad

Tap the **frequency** on the top bar to open the keypad. Enter frequency in MHz format:

- **14.074** for 14.074 MHz
- **1.832** for 1.832 MHz
- **14.074.250** for 14,074,250 Hz — a third group is hertz within the kilohertz

Each group after a **.** is padded to three digits, so **14.07** is 14.070 MHz, not 14.007. Type a number with **no . at all** and it is taken as plain hertz.

The digit layout toggles between **10 Key** (calculator order, 7-8-9 on the top row) and **Phone** (1-2-3 on the top row). Pick whichever your fingers already know — the choice persists across reboots.

Resize the keypad: Pinch it or swipe up/down on it to toggle between the normal and a compact layout. Your choice is remembered across reboots. The compact layout reveals more of the spectrum behind it.

Reposition the keypad: Drag it by the **"Enter freq"** title label (the only non-button area at the top of the panel) to move it anywhere on screen, clamped to stay fully visible. The position is remembered so it reopens exactly where you left it.

The background behind the keypad is intentionally semi-transparent (40% dim) so the spectrum and waterfall stay visible while you're entering a frequency.

Cancel and Enter are the only exits — tapping outside the keypad does nothing, so an accidental background touch cannot silently discard what you were typing.

2.7. Memory Channels

32 memory channels (4×8 grid), free to hold any frequency/mode — not tied to a band. Each stores frequency, mode, and name. Swipe up from the bottom edge to open the memory picker.

Mode is shown in colour on each button — CW (green), DiGi (teal), USB (brick red), LSB (purple) — so the grid is scannable at a glance without reading every label.

To recall a channel: Tap it. The QMX retunes immediately.

To create a new channel (empty slot): Tap the empty slot — the frequency keypad opens directly. No long-press needed.

To edit an existing channel: Long-press it in place. Change the name, frequency, or mode, then tap **Save**.

To move a channel to a different slot: Long-press and drag it to any empty slot. Release to drop. Only the data moves — the grid positions stay fixed.

To save the current QMX frequency/mode to a slot:

1. Swipe ↑ to open the memory picker
2. Long-press the slot you want to overwrite
3. The current frequency/mode pre-fills the editor — adjust the label if you like, then tap **Save**

To delete a channel — drag it onto the wastebin: the bottom-right cell (channel 32) is a **wastebin**. Long-press any filled channel and drag it onto the wastebin to delete it (it fades out). This is the way to clear a slot you no longer want.

Example channels on first use. A brand-new device ships with a few example channels already filled in (rather than 32 blank cells), so the grid is explorable straight away. These only seed empty slots — they never overwrite anything you've saved.

First-run tour. The very first time you open the memory picker, a brief (~10-second) one-time animation shows that channels can be **dragged** to move them and **dropped on the wastebin** to delete them. It plays once and never again.

Out-of-band frequencies are rejected immediately — if you enter a frequency outside a recognised amateur band, the keypad stays open so you can correct it rather than silently saving a wrong value.

2.8. Band Presets

Tap the **band name** on the top bar to switch between configured bands. The band selector shows:

- **160m, 80m, 60m, 40m, 30m, 20m, 17m, 15m, 12m, 10m, 6m** — standard bands (whichever your radio has configured)
- **11m** — the CB segment (26.9–27.5 MHz), shown on QMX+ radios that expose it
- **Custom** — user-added bands (via settings)

On radios with many configured bands (QMX+), the picker lays the bands out in **two side-by-side columns** so every band is visible without scrolling. Selecting a band jumps to the **nearest** band centre, so closely-spaced bands like 10 m and 11 m are no longer confused for one another.

Switching bands **remembers the last frequency you visited on each band**, so you can flip between 20m and 40m without losing your place.

2.9. Zoom & Pan

The QMX sends a 48 kHz-wide slice of I/Q, so **×1 shows 48 kHz** centred on the dial. Zooming narrows that window with a true zoom-FFT — you get finer resolution, not a stretched picture.

The zoom level is displayed on the top bar (e.g. **2.0x**). Tap it to choose a preset:

Zoom	Visible span
×1	48 kHz — the whole slice
×2	24 kHz
×4	12 kHz
×8	6 kHz — CW pile-up detail
×16	3 kHz
×24	2 kHz — individual CW signals well separated

Pinching sets any value in between; double-tap returns to ×1 and re-centres.

At zoom levels above $\times 1$ the display **pans to keep the passband centred** when you change mode or bandwidth, so the active receive area stays on screen.

2.10. S-Meter

The S-meter (top-right of the top bar) shows received signal strength on a 0–68 scale:

- **S1 to S9** — standard S-units (-130 to -73 dBm)
- **+10 to +20** — above S9 in 10 dB steps

It is a readout, not a control — there is nothing to tap, and there is no peak-hold mode. The reading is taken around the VFO's own bin (corrected for the QMX's 12 kHz IF offset), so it follows the signal you are actually listening to rather than the DC spike at the centre of the spectrum.

2.11. Settings Drawer

Swipe ← from the right edge to open the settings drawer. It is grouped, with a **Basic / Expert** toggle at the top — Basic shows the everyday items, Expert reveals the rest, so the list is short until you need it to be long.

The groups, in the order they appear:

Group	Holds	In Basic?
Station	Callsign and grid, activation, band-plan region	yes
Device	Battery charge limit	Expert only
Radio	QMX volume, RF gain, CW transmit offset, SWR limit, Antenna Tune, Release radio	yes
Network	WiFi, spot sources (POTA / RBN / DX cluster), Bluetooth mouse	yes
Display	Brightness, sleep, colour map, 180° flip	yes
FT8	Distance in miles, FT8 simulation mode	yes
Spectrum	Presets, dB range, smoothing, waterfall colouring, flat mode, I/Q balance, IF calibration	Expert only

Everything reached in a normal session is in a Basic group; the tuning and calibration controls are the ones Expert reveals.

The full list, group by group, is in [Settings](#).

Next: Learn about [FT8 Receive](#) or [Web UI](#).

Spectrum and waterfall

The display is divided into a **60 px top bar**, a **200 px spectrum** (green curve with dim fill), a **32 px frequency axis**, a **370 px waterfall**, a **22 px band-plan strip**, and a **36 px bottom bar**. The full visible span is 48 kHz centred on the QMX VFO.

The **spectrum** shows signal power in dBm (default range -130 to -30 dBm). Each frame is smoothed per-bin with an exponential moving average (EMA $\alpha = 0.4$ by default, adjustable in the drawer), balancing visual stability against snappy response to CW signals and SSB attack transients.

The **frequency axis** shows absolute MHz labels centred on the QMX VFO, refreshed on every CAT frequency update. At high zoom levels the labels resolve to kHz or Hz precision.

Band-plan strip. A thin coloured bar directly above the bottom status bar (below the waterfall) shows the coarse CW / Digi / Phone segments of the current band, with a marker for where the VFO sits within them. Pick which IARU region it reflects in the settings drawer → **Band-plan region** (Auto from your grid square, or a fixed Region 1 / 2 / 3).

The **waterfall** runs newest row at the top in a thermal SDR palette (black → dark blue → teal → green → yellow → red). Four colour maps are available in the settings drawer: Thermal, Viridis, Turbo, and Grayscale.

Waterfall floor tracking. The waterfall's black level tracks the band noise automatically — a running median sampled only from bins inside the passband, EMA-smoothed — so the background colour follows conditions rather than a fixed anchor. Bins outside the passband run darker and are excluded from the floor calculation so they don't wash out dim in-band signals.

Flat-spectrum mode (toggle in the settings drawer, persisted to NVS) switches both spectrum and waterfall to a per-bin adaptive display: each bin renders as dB above its own running noise floor. Real signals — including weak CW tones — stand out sharply against a calm baseline. This is the recommended mode on noisy bands. The dB range sliders have no effect in flat mode; the axis shows relative dB above floor.

Touch-to-tune

Tap anywhere on the spectrum or waterfall to place the cyan tune cursor. Drag and the cursor snaps grid-point to grid-point — you can see exactly which frequency will be tuned before you lift. The snap grid is **mode-aware**:

Tune vs. pan — how your finger is read. A quick horizontal swipe (more than ~70 px within 250 ms) pans the view instead of tuning — see [Zoom and pan](#). A slower touch-and-hold (250 ms without that much movement) locks into tune mode, after which dragging moves the snap cursor as described below. In short: swipe fast to pan, hold-then-drag to tune.

Mode	Snap step
CW / CW-R	10 Hz
USB / LSB	250 Hz
FT8 / DiGi / RTTY	500 Hz
AM	1 kHz

The grid is anchored to absolute frequency (e.g. ...200 / 300 / 400 Hz), not to your touch start point, so the cursor always lands on the same set of grid points regardless of where your finger first touches.

A floating frequency tooltip above the cursor shows the target frequency in real time while dragging. Lift → CAT FA command is sent; QMX retunes; spectrum re-centres.

Taps always tune to exactly where you touched (snapped to the mode-aware grid above). The old **Snap to signal** option — which hunted for the strongest bin near your tap — was removed in v0.19.4; predictable tuning won.

Passband indicator. Two grey vertical lines mark your current filter edges. A faint coloured tint fills the passband. The amber VFO marker shows where the QMX is tuned; in CW mode it sits at dial + CW pitch offset so it marks the actual received tone frequency, not the suppressed carrier.

Zoom and pan

Gesture	Effect
One-finger fast horizontal swipe	Pan/"stroll" the view — retunes to the new centre frequency on release
Pinch (two fingers)	Zoom $\times 1.0$ – $\times 24.0$
Two-finger drag	Pan the zoomed window
Double-tap	Reset zoom and pan to $\times 1.0$ / centred
Top-bar Zoom → tap	Zoom preset: $\times 1$ / $\times 2$ / $\times 4$ / $\times 8$ / $\times 16$ / $\times 24$

One-finger pan (stroll). A fast horizontal swipe — more than ~ 70 px of movement within the first 250 ms of touching down — slides the spectrum and waterfall under your finger in real time, with a live frequency tooltip, and retunes to wherever you release. This works at any zoom level alongside the two-finger pinch/pan above; it's the quickest way to slide along a band without lifting into a deliberate tune-drag.

At zoom $> \times 1$ the view **centres on the passband** (not the VFO dial), which matters for USB/LSB where the passband sits offset from the carrier. The passband lines and frequency axis track correctly at all zoom levels. Zoom level is persisted to NVS and restores with full zoom-FFT resolution on the next boot.

S-meter

The Signal field in the top bar is a visual tick-scale bar labelled S1, S3, S5, S7, S9, +10, +20 with a moving green bar beneath. It is driven by the peak dBm in a ± 64 -bin window centred on the IF-shifted VFO bin — the actual signal under your cursor, not the DC/LO artefact at bin 0.

S-unit mapping: S9 = -73 dBm; 6 dB per S-unit below S9; 1 dB per unit above S9. The meter stays live during FT8 capture.

Memory channels

Swipe up from the bottom edge (or tap the bottom grip handle) to open the 4×8 memory channel grid (32 slots, NVS-persisted).

Action	How
Recall	Tap a slot — QMX retunes to stored frequency and mode
Create	Tap an empty slot — the frequency/mode picker opens directly
Edit	Long-press an occupied slot
Move	Long-press and drag a filled slot onto an empty one — the data follows your finger
Delete	Drag a filled slot onto the wastebin (bottom-right cell, channel 32) — it fades out

Memory slots show the label in large text and mode + frequency (dimmed) below. The frequency/mode picker pre-fills the current VFO and lets you edit both before naming.

A new device ships with a few **example channels** already filled (rather than 32 blank cells), seeded only into empty slots so they never overwrite anything you've saved. The **first time** you open the picker, a brief one-time (~10 s) tour demonstrates the drag-to-move and drag-to-wastebin gestures, then never plays again.

Settings drawer

Open by swiping in from the right edge, or tapping the right grip handle. The drawer is scrollable.

It is grouped, with a Basic / Expert toggle at the top. Basic shows what a normal session needs; Expert adds the tuning and calibration controls. The groups, in order:

Group	Controls	Basic?
Station	Identity (callsign + grid), Activation (POTA/SOTA), Band-plan region	yes
Device	Battery charge limit	Expert
Radio	QMX volume, QMX RF gain, CW transmit offset, SWR protection, Antenna Tune (<i>QMX 1.04+</i>), Release radio	yes
Network	WiFi, Live spots (POTA / RBN / DX cluster), Bluetooth mouse	yes
Display	Brightness, Display sleep, Waterfall colour map, Flip 180°	yes
FT8	Distance in miles, FT8 simulation mode	yes
Spectrum	Presets, dB range, Smoothing, Waterfall controls, Flat spectrum, I/Q balance, IF calibration	Expert

The FT8 group only appears on the FT8 screen, and the spectrum-related groups drop away there.

What each control does:

Control	What it does
Activation	Start a POTA or SOTA activation; every logged contact then carries the reference, with the count shown against the threshold. See Activation
SWR protection	Off / 2.0 / 2.5 / 3.0 / 4.0 : 1 — above the limit the transmitter latches off. See SWR protection
Release radio	Stops all CAT traffic so you can use the QMX's own menus without the Tab5 interrupting them
QMX RF gain	The radio's RF gain in dB, per band , read back from the radio — nothing is stored on the Tab5, because a remembered value would belong to whichever band you were last on
CW transmit offset	Transmit a few hundred hertz off the station you are answering, so you stand out of the zero-beat pile. Implemented as split, because the QMX has no XIT
Live spots	The POTA, RBN and DX cluster sources for the spot lane
Bluetooth mouse	A pointer that works while the QMX is plugged in. See Bluetooth mouse
Display sleep	Backlight off after an idle timeout; a tap wakes it and is swallowed, so nothing is triggered by accident
Flip 180°	Inverts the whole display and touch axes for upside-down mounting; centred checkbox so it isn't hit by accident, persisted
QMX volume	The radio's own AF gain, in decibels — the same number the QMX shows on its LCD (verified side by side against a real QMX). Reads the rig back each time the drawer opens, so it stays in step if you use the radio's volume knob. Intended for QMX+ builds with no control panel, where there is no knob at all. Spans 0–50 dB, not the QMX's full 0–199 dB, so the useful travel isn't crammed into the first couple of centimetres — 50 dB is Randy N4OPI's with-antenna figure. Turn the rig's own knob past 50 and the slider knob pins at the end while the number keeps showing the true dB

Control	What it does
IQ Balance	Toggle adaptive I/Q image correction; re-enabling resets the estimator
Flat spectrum	Toggle flat/absolute display mode, persisted
Presets	HF Normal / HF DX / Strong Sig — sets dB range and smoothing in one tap
WiFi	Opens credential modal; WiFi initiated checkbox enables/disables WiFi entirely
Identity	Callsign + Maidenhead grid (required for FT8/FT4 TX; also drives KM/BRG columns)
Band-plan region	Auto (from your grid square) / Region 1 (EU/AF) / Region 2 (Americas) / Region 3 (Asia/Pac) — drives the band-plan strip ; sits right under Identity since Auto derives from your grid
dB Range	Min and Max sliders (dBm)
Smoothing	EMA alpha 0.05–1.00
CW	CW sidetone centre, 600–800 Hz; touch-to-tune in CW mode snaps to this offset, persisted
IF calibration	±100 Hz trim for per-unit LO variance (see Per-unit IF calibration)
Display	Brightness, 10–100%, persisted
Battery charge limit	Optionally stop charging at a set percentage (default 80%) to reduce long-term pack wear; charging resumes automatically if the level later drops well below it (5% hysteresis). The displayed charge % now also compensates for the voltage rise while charging, so it no longer jumps around when plugged in
Waterfall colour map	Thermal / Viridis / Turbo / Grayscale, persisted
Waterfall	Black level, Contrast, Adaptive floor blend, and FFT window — see Waterfall colourisation below

Grouped, with a Basic/Expert toggle (v1.6.0). The drawer had grown to twenty-five sections in the order they were built, so related controls were scattered — the two QMX gain controls sat together, but CW pitch was nine sections away from the CW transmit offset. It is now grouped under headings — **Station, Device, Radio, Network, Display, FT8, Spectrum** — and the toggle beside the **Settings** title chooses how much you see. It always says where you are and what a tap gives you: **BASIC (tap for Expert)** reveals the Spectrum and Device groups, which hold the calibration and tuning controls you set once and rarely revisit. Nothing is lost in Basic, only hidden, and the choice is not remembered between sessions — it is a way of looking at the drawer rather than a preference.

The **Radio** group is where the controls that reach the QMX live: **QMX volume, QMX RF gain** (per band, read back from the radio), the **CW transmit offset, Antenna Tune** on 1.04+ firmware, and **Release radio to QMX menu**.

Earlier declutter, still true: the **Snap to signal** and **FT8 sync lines** toggles were removed in v0.19.4 (taps now always tune where you touch).

On the FT8 screen the spectrum-related groups drop away and three FT8-only controls appear: **Distance in miles** for the decode list's KM/MI column, **Fast pounce (early decode)** — see below — and **FT8 Simulation Mode**, see [FT8 Simulation mode](#).

Fast pounce (early decode) — on by default. Decodes surface ~1.8 s *before* the slot boundary (the way WSJT-X decodes in the dead-air gap), so replying to a fresh CQ can transmit in the very next slot instead of waiting a full 30 s cycle, and mid-QSO replies land on the beat. The trade-off: the capture window closes ~1.8 s early, so a station transmitting *late* in the slot can occasionally be clipped and missed. ⚠️ This feature has not yet been A/B-verified on a live band — if your decodes-per-slot drop noticeably with it on, turn it off here and please report your before/after numbers on the groups.io thread.

Waterfall colourisation

Four live, NVS-persisted sliders/dropdown at the bottom of the settings drawer fine-tune how the waterfall maps signal to colour — changes scroll in from the top as you drag:

Control	Range	Default	Effect
Black level	0–30 dB	9 dB	How far above each bin's own noise floor a signal needs to be before it lifts off black
Contrast	10–80 dB	45 dB	The dB span that fills the rest of the colour ramp above the black level
Adaptive floor	0–100%	100%	Blend between a per-bin noise floor (100%) and one global mean floor across the band (0%)
FFT window	Blackman-Harris / Hann (sharp) / Nuttall	Blackman-Harris	The FFT window function; Hann trades some sidelobe suppression for sharper peaks

Live spots on the spectrum

(needs WiFi) Callsigns drawn straight onto the trace, at the frequency the station is actually using. Three sources, each switched on separately in **Network** → **Live spots**:

Source	What it carries	Default
POTA	Park activations, self-spotted by the activator	on
RBN	CW skimmer reports — machines listening for CW, RTTY, FT8 and FT4	off
DX cluster	People typing. This is where SSB spots come from: no machine recognises a callsign spoken into a microphone, so phone activity is structurally invisible to RBN	off

Colours: amber is a POTA activation, green an RBN spot, and **grey** a station you have already worked *on that band*.

Press and drag to pick one, and lift to tune it — frequency *and* mode. Bandwidth is deliberately left alone, since the QMX keeps a filter per mode. Counts in the bottom corners (< spots (3)) say how many more are on this band just outside your window; tap one to jump to the nearest.

Spots fade with age and are gone after 30 minutes. On a crowded band only so many labels fit — unworked and fresher spots keep theirs, and a spot that cannot fit a label is not drawn at all rather than left as a line pointing at nothing.

One station, one entry. A station spotted on POTA *and* heard by RBN used to be drawn twice, in two colours, a few pixels apart — and RBN doubled itself where two skimmers rounded the same signal differently. The same callsign within 2 kHz is now a single entry: the activation spot wins, and the RBN sighting folds into it as corroboration, shown as a brighter marker. That distinction is worth having — it means *a receiver copied them just now*, rather than *somebody typed this an hour ago*.

3. Web UI

With the Tab5 on WiFi, open `http://<tab5-ip>` in any modern browser. The IP is shown in the bottom status bar on the Tab5.

The browser panadapter is a full-featured view in its own right — not just a window onto the Tab5. On a larger monitor you get more spectrum history, a bigger waterfall canvas, and mouse controls that are faster than touch for precise tuning. It shows live spectrum at ≈ 10 fps via WebSocket, full waterfall history (~ 50 s), the same thermal palette and floor maths, a graphical S-meter, and a top bar with Band / Mode / BW / Zoom controls. The bottom bar shows battery percentage + voltage, firmware version, a live UTC clock, and WiFi SSID + RSSI. To its right: download/upload buttons (ADIF, QRZ, eQSL — see [QSO logging](#)), **Files** ▲ → **Diagnostic download** ↓ for the diagnostic logs, **Config** ↓ / **Config** ↑ to back up / restore / edit all settings (see [Config backup, restore & edit](#)), and **Tab5Shot** which opens a live `/ss.bmp` screenshot in a new tab.

microSD file browser (new in v1.3.0). **Files** → **SD Files** in the bottom bar opens `http://<tab5-ip>/files` — browse the microSD card from any computer without pulling it: download your logs and config backups, upload files, delete. Card access is coordinated with the WiFi link the same way the automatic backup is, so it's safe to use mid-session.

Whole-band plan strip & adjustable split (new in v0.20.0). Along the bottom of the browser view (above the status bar), a colour-coded CW/Digi/Phone strip spans the entire band with a draggable "visible window" (drag or tap to retune) and a VFO marker, mirroring the Tab5's own strip. Drag the divider between the spectrum and the waterfall to give either more room — the split is remembered in the browser. **Tab5Shot** now captures any open pop-up (band/mode dropdown) too, and the frequency keypad is draggable with a standard 10-key layout.

In FT8/FT4 mode the live stream pauses (new in v0.20.0). The browser stops streaming the spectrum/waterfall and shows a notice plus the log and upload controls instead. While you're operating digital modes the stream would compete with the on-device decoder and the WiFi link, so pausing it keeps FT8 decoding and WiFi noticeably steadier. Switch the Tab5 back to Panadapter mode and the stream resumes automatically.

Live TX status, and Call CQ from the browser. In FT8/FT4 mode that same panel carries a **TX status banner** (v1.3.6) mirroring the Tab5's own label — red while transmitting including the "call 2 of 4" counter, amber armed, green on QSO complete, orange on timeout, plus the persistent "CQ stopped after N calls - no answer"; the browser tab title shows a red dot while transmitting, visible even in a background tab. Under it is a **Call CQ** button (v1.5.0, Dennis WN4FLA), so a CQ run that timed out or reached its call limit can be restarted without walking back to the radio. It **confirms first** — it keys the radio, and a mis-click from another room should not put a carrier on the air — then uses exactly what the Tab5 would: the active CQ preset, the current TX tone (honouring TX Hold) and the TXCQ ANY/EVEN/ODD parity, sharing one code path with the Tab5's own button so the two cannot drift. The request is handed to the display task, so the button greys out for a moment; watch the banner rather than the button. A request arriving while the Tab5 is not in FT8 is discarded, never queued. Replies and pounces are still initiated on the Tab5, where the decode list is.

Click or drag to tune. Click or drag on the spectrum or waterfall — a cyan cursor appears with a live frequency readout and commits on release.

Mouse-wheel to pan or tune. Rolling the mouse wheel over the spectrum or waterfall **pans** the view when zoomed in, letting you survey the band without touching the Tab5. At zoom ×1 the wheel **tunes** with mode-aware snap (CW 10 Hz, SSB 500 Hz, DiGi 100 Hz, AM 1 kHz).

Band / Mode / BW / Zoom dropdown pills in the top bar send commands to the QMX via `/api/cmd` — the same effect as using the Tab5 top bar.

Zoom sync. The browser renders the same zoomed window as the Tab5.

QSO log — download, view, edit. Once you have logged at least one completed FT8 QSO, a "**QSO Logs (N) ▲**" menu appears in the bottom bar of the web UI. **ADIF download** ↓ fetches your `qso.adf` file directly. **View / edit log** (v1.3.5) opens the whole log as a table in the browser — click any column header to sort (click again to reverse; sorting by date groups an activation's QSOs together), delete a single record with the ✕ on its row, or **Delete all** to clear the log (it asks you to type `DELETE`, because there is no undo — download the ADIF first if you want a copy). The menu is only shown when the log contains data.

QRZ / eQSL upload. Two more buttons appear alongside the ADIF link once you have logged QSOs — see [QSO logging](#) for the full picture.

Config backup, restore & edit

The **Config** ↓ / **Config** ↑ buttons in the bottom bar let you save every setting to a plain text file, edit it on your PC, restore it, or share parts of it.

- **Config** ↓ downloads `qmx-config.txt` — a human-readable [INI-style](#) file with everything the Tab5 remembers, grouped into sections:
 - `[settings]` — callsign, grid, WiFi SSID/password, CW pitch, IF trim, IQ balance, flat-spectrum, zoom, colour map, brightness, dB range, EMA, GPS toggle, keypad layout, QRZ key, eQSL user/pass.
 - `[cq]` — the three FT8 CQ-message presets and which is active.
 - `[ft8_filters]` — the CQ-run include/exclude filter terms and toggles.
 - `[memories]` — the 32 memory channels, one per line: `slot = freq_hz, mode, label`.
- **Config** ↑ picks an edited file and **merges** it back: only the keys and sections present in the file are changed — everything else is left as-is. Unknown keys are ignored (so a file from a newer firmware still loads). Memory channels apply immediately; other settings take effect after a restart.

Three things you can do with it:

1. **Back up before a clean flash.** Hit **Config** ↓ first, do the clean/erase flash, then **Config** ↑ to restore everything in seconds — instead of re-typing it all on glass.
2. **Edit in a text editor instead of on the touchscreen.** Faster for callsign, grid, CQ messages, or punching in a batch of memory channels.
3. **Share a band plan.** Copy just the `[memories]` section into a message — another operator pastes it into their file and uploads it to get the same channels (their other settings untouched).

The downloaded file contains your **WiFi password** and **QRZ/eQSL credentials in clear text** (so it works as a full backup). Keep it private; strip those lines before sharing a file with anyone.

Endpoints

Endpoint	Method	Returns
/	GET	Browser panadapter (HTML)
/api/status	GET	JSON status (see below)
/api/cmd	POST	Send Band/Mode/BW/Zoom commands
/api/log	GET	Diagnostic log download (qmx-log.txt)
/api/log/saved	GET	Flash-persisted diagnostic log from before the last reboot/power-off
/api/adif	GET	ADIF QSO log download (qso.adf)
/api/adif/clear	POST	Wipe ADIF log and worked-call cache; resets the QRZ/eQSL/LotW upload positions
/api/adif/delete	POST	Delete one record: ?idx=<n>&call=<CALL> — both must match the record or it answers 409
/api/qrz_key	POST	Save QRZ Logbook API key (body = raw key text)
/api/qrz_upload	POST	Upload pending QSOs to QRZ Logbook; returns {uploaded, failed, error}
/api/eqsl_creds	POST	Save eQSL username/password (JSON body {"user", "pswd"})
/api/eqsl_upload	POST	Upload pending QSOs to eQSL (batched); returns {uploaded, failed, error}
/api/config	GET	Download all settings + memory channels as editable INI (qmx-config.txt)
/api/config	POST	Upload an INI config; merges into NVS; returns {applied}
/ss.bmp	GET	1280×720 RGB565 BMP screenshot
/ws	WS	Binary spectrum stream (~10 fps)

/api/status

```
{
  "battery":    { "level": 100, "mv": 8320, "charging": true },
  "wifi":       { "ssid": "MyNet", "rssi": -44, "ip": "192.168.1.213" },
  "freq_hz":    14074000,
  "mode":       "USB",
  "band":       "20m",
  "passband_hz": 2700,
  "signal_dbm": -87.4,
  "zoom":       1.0,
  "pan_bins":   0,
  "flat_mode":  false,
  "utc_epoch":  1750000000,
  "qso_count":  12,
  "qrz_key_set": false,
  "eqsl_creds_set": false,
  "tab5_fw":    "v0.18.8",
  "qmx_fw":     "1_03_002QMX"
}
```

Polled at 1 Hz by the landing page; safe to consume from monitoring scripts, home automation, etc. `qmx_fw` is read from the QMX via the `vn`; CAT command at link-up (empty until the radio responds). `signal_dbm` is the peak dBm around the IF-shifted VFO bin (null if DSP has no data yet). `qrz_key_set` / `eqsl_creds_set` tell the web UI whether to prompt for credentials before the next upload.

/ws — binary spectrum WebSocket

Single-client endpoint. Each binary frame is 1026 bytes:

Bytes	Meaning
0	Frame type: 0x01 = spectrum
1	Zoom decimation factor (1 = base 1024-bin spectrum, >1 = zoom-FFT with that decimation)
2–1025	1024 unsigned bytes, one per bin, quantised –130 dBm (0) to –30 dBm (255)

Bins are pre-shifted server-side so byte 2 is the leftmost screen pixel. Push rate $\approx$ 10 fps.

Screenshots

```
Invoke-WebRequest -Uri "http://192.168.1.213/ss.bmp" -OutFile screenshot.bmp
```

Who is hearing me

(needs WiFi) **Miscellaneous** → **Who is hearing me** asks PSK Reporter which receivers have copied **your** callsign recently, and lists them by distance with the country, bearing, and the signal report they gave you.

This is the reverse of the reports the panadapter *sends*, and the two are separate settings — you can have either without the other. Switch it on in the browser under **Settings** → **Spots & reporting**; there is deliberately no Tab5 control, because the answer is a table of distances and bearings that wants a screen you are already sitting in front of.

It answers the one question no amount of local processing can: **am I actually getting out?** The valuable case is the mismatch. Stations you can hear that cannot hear you is a transmit-side problem — antenna, power, a bad connector — and from the receiving side alone that looks exactly like a dead band.

It is read-only, and asks at most once every five minutes because that is the rate PSK Reporter requests. An empty list is the normal answer until you have transmitted: nobody can report hearing a station that has not been on the air.

4. FT8 Receive

The panadapter includes **on-device FT8 and FT4 decoders** with real-time spectrum waterfall and a live list of heard stations.

4.1. FT8 & FT4 View

Swipe → from the left edge to toggle to FT8/FT4 view. The same decode list and waterfall work for both modes — switch modes via the **Preset** dropdown in the left pane (top).

FT4 notes:

- Decodes refresh roughly twice as fast as FT8 because slots are 7.5 seconds
- Slot countdown shows 7.5 s instead of 15 s

- All filtering, priority, and auto-reply features work identically in FT4
- Time-sync from decoded signal timing works in both FT4 and FT8 (the bottom-bar clock shows UTC(FT4) when synced from an FT4 decode)
- **v0.19.4 made FT4 reliable**: a memory-placement fault previously killed decoding on every other slot (FT8's longer slots mostly hid it), the EVEN/ODD slot markers were on the wrong 15-second grid, and the slot clock could visibly jump between slots — all fixed; if FT4 seemed deaf or erratic on an earlier version, update the firmware

You'll see:

- **Decode list** (left pane) — every station heard, ordered so the ones that matter to you are at the top (see [Decode List](#) below)
- **Waterfall** (right pane) — same real-time spectrum as panadapter mode
- **Call CQ button** — start a CQ (requires QMX on the air)
- **Filter button** — include/exclude stations, prioritise by SNR/distance, show only CQ callers

4.2. Decode List

The list shows every decoded FT8 message:

Column	Meaning
SL	Slot parity: E (blue) or O (amber)
CALL	Their callsign
MESSAGE	The full decoded message text
CTY	Country as a 3-letter code (from the callsign prefix)
SNR	Signal-to-noise estimate, colour-banded by strength
DT	Slot-timing offset in seconds, relative to the band — an on-time station reads ~0.0 (v1.3.1)
HZ	The station's audio tone within the FT8 passband (v1.3.1)
KM / MI	Great-circle distance from your grid
BRG	Bearing from your grid
HRD	Times decoded since last appearance

Own call highlight — your callsign is shown in **inverted colours** (red fill, white text) so you spot replies to you instantly.

How the list is ordered. Top to bottom:

1. **The station you are working** (asked for by Don WB0LQW) — during an exchange there are several transmissions each way, and the partner's messages used to sort down-screen where you had to hunt for them. Now *everything* from them stays at the top: their reply to you, their CQ while you are mid-exchange, and a message they send to a third station — which is exactly when you most want to see it. It covers a hand-typed reply as well as an automatic exchange, and matches on their **callsign**, so a third station merely mentioning them is not promoted. It releases the moment the QSO completes (their closing 73 contains your callsign, so rule 2 keeps it up there anyway).
2. **Messages addressed to you** — anything containing your callsign.
3. **CQ calls.**
4. **Everything else, strongest signal first.**

Stale entries — the list is a live picture of who's on frequency now; stations not heard again within **2 minutes** drop off automatically.

During your own CQ run — stations transmitting on *your* transmit slot (which you can't hear while transmitting) are hidden from the list and return when the run ends; other stations' CQ rows are hidden during a run as before.

Nonstandard callsigns — special-event and compound calls now resolve to the full callsign instead of showing <...>, once the station has been heard in full.

4.3. Filtering & Priority

Tap the **Filter** button to open the filter modal:

- **Include callsigns** — only show these calls (space or comma-separated)
- **Include callsigns containing** — show any call with these substrings (e.g., /P for portable)
- **Exclude callsigns** — hide these calls
- **Exclude if contains** — hide any call matching these substrings
- **Exclude worked before** — skip calls you've already logged QSOs with
- **Show only CQ callers** — hide replies, show only CQ messages
- **Skip TX1** — when you pounce a station, open with your signal report straight away instead of the grid exchange, for a quicker QSO (falls back to the normal grid exchange if the station has dropped out of the decode list)

- **Allow grey-listing** — off by default. A station that times out two of your pounces in a row is set aside: the robot and Auto-work-pileup skip it, its decode row turns **violet**, and tapping it offers to clear it from the grey-list instead of opening the TX dialog. Handy on a busy band where one station simply never comes back. The list is held in memory only and forgotten at power-off
- **Auto-reply priority** — Strongest SNR, Weakest SNR, Most distant grid
- **Robot mode** — auto-answer CQ (disabled by default; see [FT8 Transmit](#))

All filters persist across sessions. Toggle any filter on/off to enable or disable it without erasing the criteria.

4.4. Decoding Performance

On a reasonably busy band, expect roughly **15–20 distinct messages per slot** in either mode. That is messages, not contacts — one QSO produces several.

Decoding uses **both processor cores**: the decode task works one half of the candidate list on core 1 while a helper takes the other half on core 0, and both run against a waterfall that was built during the capture rather than after it. That is what makes the results appear a second or two into the following slot instead of most of the way through it.

What limits it:

- **LDPC error correction is heavy**, and most candidates the search finds are false alarms that use the full iteration budget before being discarded
- **The spectrum and waterfall** are being drawn from the same audio at the same time
- **USB audio must be serviced continuously** — a gap there costs decodes far more than a slow decoder does

FT4 advantage: because FT4 slots are half as long (7.5 s vs 15 s), you get refresh feedback roughly twice as fast, which feels snappier on a crowded band even though the per-slot decode count is the same.

The panadapter prioritises **receive latency** (decode every 15 s, not accumulate) over volume.

4.5. Real-Time Waterfall

Unlike WSJT-X (which buffers a whole 15-second capture), the Tab5 **builds the waterfall on-the-fly** as audio arrives. You see CW and other traffic in real time, and FT8 stations appear instantly as their symbol blocks are decoded.

The waterfall also shows **non-FT8 activity**:

- CW (carrier lines)
- SSB (broader vertical smears)
- RTTY (FSK sidebands)
- Interference (wideband noise)

4.6. Tap to Reply

Tap any FT8 row in the decode list to **prepare a reply**:

1. A confirmation modal pops up showing your message
2. You can review the target callsign, grid, and SNR
3. Tap **Transmit** to send, or **Cancel** to abort

The reply always follows FT8 protocol (correct parity, proper message sequence) — you can't accidentally send a garbled or out-of-order message.

Pile-up list. If a station answers you while you're busy with another contact, they used to disappear from the list once they stopped transmitting. They're now remembered in a **Pileup** list — the **ADIF-log** button on the FT8 screen turns into a **Pileup** button (a different colour) whenever callers are waiting. Tap it to see who's called you, tap a station to work them, or tap the × to dismiss one. See [FT8 Transmit](#) for the full workflow.

4.7. Auto-Reply (Robot Mode)

 **Experimental** — enabled via a checkbox in the Filter modal.

When robot mode is on, the Tab5 **automatically replies to CQ** without waiting for you to tap. It scans each FT8 slot for CQ callers matching your filters, picks the highest-priority station, and sends a full QSO exchange (TX1 → wait for report → TX2 → wait for RR73 → TX3). Everything is logged to ADIF.

Important: Robot mode **keys the QMX for real** — your signal goes on the air. Never leave it unattended unless you're confident in your filters and your station is in a safe state.

4.8. Search & Window

The decoder uses an **FFT-based search window** to find candidate tone blocks, at whichever tone spacing the active mode uses — **6.25 Hz** for FT8's 8 tones, **20.83 Hz** for FT4's 4.

Frequency stability: The QMX's USB audio clock isn't bit-exact 48 kHz, so decodes slide slowly over time. The panadapter **re-locks to UTC boundaries every 15 seconds** (the slot boundary), preventing long-term drift.

4.9. Time Sync for FT8

FT8 requires **UTC time accurate to ± 1 second** for slot synchronisation. The panadapter gets time from:

1. **WiFi + SNTP** (if available) — most accurate, syncs every ~hour
2. **Tab5 RTC** (if set) — accurate to ± 1 min, no internet needed (POTA)
3. **QMX GPS** (if QMX has GPS) — re-syncs the RTC every 5 minutes
4. **Manual** — you can set time via the settings drawer

See [Time Sync](#) for details.

Next: Learn about [FT8 Transmit](#) or go back to [Panadapter](#).

Band: 20m Mode: DiGi BW: 3.2 kHz Freq: 14.074.000 Hz S1 3 5 7 9 +20 Zoom: x1.0

MODE: FT8

Preset: 14.074 MHz

07:44:22 UTC

ODD 8 s

TX: EVEN TX: ODD

Active: 16

ME: OZ1LAV JO65FR

Call CQ

RX: 0 decoded (67 candidates)

SL	CALL	MESSAGE	COUNTRY	SNR	KM	BRG	HRD
○	DL5DQZ	CQ DL5DQZ JO61	Germany	-5 dB	472	175°	8
○	SQ9FVE	CQ SQ9FVE JO90	Poland	-6 dB	726	140°	21
○	PD0XTL	CQ PD0XTL JO21	Netherlands	-7 dB	680	229°	8
○	IK2UJS	CQ IK2UJS JN55	Italy	-14 dB	1142	186°	24
○	IK4LZH	CQ IK4LZH JN54	Italy	-18 dB	1253	185°	2
○	PD1ADA	G0ABI PD1ADA JO21	Netherlands	+0 dB	680	229°	7
○	DL9AJ	XE1YD DL9AJ JO52	Germany	-1 dB	371	195°	4
○	F8BJE	W0VIX F8BJE JN27	France	-9 dB	1049	212°	5
○	DC1AVL	TA4INO DC1AVL JO30	Germany	-9 dB	686	214°	4
○	G0ANH	DL6RDE G0ANH 73	England	-14 dB	--	--	1
○	F1PSX	N5CH F1PSX JN08	France	-14 dB	1119	229°	5
○	F5OYA/P	EA5PC F5OYA/P JN13	France	-15 dB	1518	210°	2
○	MI9PBM	G8IXM MI9PBM -07	N. Ireland	-15 dB	--	--	19
○	UB8CPH	G6INI UB8CPH -10	Russia	-16 dB	--	--	10
○	S57XX	RA1QX S57XX 73	Slovenia	-16 dB	--	--	9
○	<...>	TM150BEL <...> 73	--	-18 dB	--	--	1

100% (8.3V) v0.15.7 07:44:23 UTC BV50 - 75dBm 192.168.1.213

Live FT8 reception on 20 m (v0.15.7). Left pane: MODE / Preset freq / UTC / slot countdown with parity and progress bar / TX parity preference / operator identity / Call CQ / decode summary. Right pane: scrollable decode list.

Swipe in from the **left edge** to switch to the FT8 screen. The Tab5 decodes 15-second FT8 slots directly on the ESP32-P4 — no PC, no WSJT-X.

Prerequisites

- **WiFi configured** — recommended for accurate UTC time. Without it the Tab5 falls back to its supercap RTC or the QMX clock. See [Time sync](#).
- **Callsign and grid** set in the drawer → **Identity** if you want distance/bearing columns or plan to transmit.

The FT8 screen

Left pane: MODE label · **Preset** frequency button (tap to pick a band's conventional FT8 dial frequency) · UTC clock · 15-second slot countdown with current parity (EVEN blue / ODD amber) and a gliding progress bar · **live mini occupancy strip** (the audio window as 50 Hz cells, same data and colours as the tone picker) · **TXCQ ANY / EVEN / ODD** parity-preference button (one button, cycles) · **TX nnnn Hz** tone button · **Call CQ** button · last-slot decode summary and TX status.

Right pane — decode list:

Column	Content
SL	Slot parity: E (blue, :00/:30) or O (amber, :15/:45)
CALL	Extracted callsign
MESSAGE	Full decoded FT8 message text
CTY	DXCC entity as a 3-letter code (ISO alpha-3 where it exists; ~190 entities)
SNR	FFT-based estimate, colour-banded: green ≥ 0 / white $-5..-1$ / orange $-15..-6$ / grey < -15
DT	Slot-timing offset in seconds, relative to the band — an on-time station reads ~ 0.0
HZ	The station's audio tone (its offset within the FT8 passband)
KM	Great-circle distance from your grid
BRG	Bearing from your grid
HRD	Times decoded since last appearance

CQ calls always appear at the top sorted strongest-SNR first; all other rows follow by SNR descending.

Row colour scheme (CALL + MESSAGE columns): **white** for ordinary traffic, **green** for plain cq calls, **dim grey** for callsigns already worked **on the current band** (a station you worked on 20 m still shows normally on 40 m — see [Reply filter](#) for hiding them entirely), and **inverted red fill + white text** for any message containing your own callsign — your highest-priority rows literally pop off the screen instead of relying on red-on-black text, which field testing found hard to read at a glance.

Live view. Stations not re-decoded within 60 seconds drop off the list automatically, even while the band is quiet — the list is who's on frequency *now*, not a cumulative history. (The "Active: N" counter that used to say so was dropped in v1.3.4; the wrapping TX/QSO status text took its line.)

Performance

On a busy 20 m FT8 slot the decoder regularly yields 25–50 callsigns per slot. Both EVEN and ODD slots decode every cycle via a ping-pong dual-buffer architecture — a TX slot never causes the opposite parity to be skipped. Heap is stable across long sessions (~39 KB internal RAM free, 25 MB PSRAM free during decoding).

5. FT8 Transmit

The panadapter **keys the QMX and transmits full FT8/FT4 QSOs** — reply to CQ, run your own CQ, auto-answer (robot mode), or conduct a full exchange.

5.1. FT8 vs FT4 — Which to Use?

Both modes transmit via the same CAT interface; the difference is **slot length and symbol rate**:

Feature	FT8	FT4
Slot length	15 seconds	7.5 seconds
Symbols transmitted	79	105
Symbol duration	160 ms	48 ms
QSO time (full exchange)	~90 sec (6 slots)	~45 sec (6 slots)
Use case	Weak signal, SOTA/POTA	Busy bands, contests
Preset picker	Panadapter mode → Freq dropdown	FT8 mode → Preset picker

Choose FT4 when:

- The band is crowded (faster exchanges, less QRM)
- You're in a contest (time is critical)
- You want quicker pileup resolution

Choose FT8 when:

- Signal is marginal (longer decode window tolerates more QRN)
- You're portable/POTA (less pressure to transmit fast)
- You prefer the relaxed pace

FT4 has full feature parity with FT8, including time-sync from decoded signals (fixed in v0.19.3 — the time-sync modal shows "FT4" when appropriate and the bottom-bar clock correctly reads UTC(FT4) while in FT4 mode).

5.2. Switching Between FT8 and FT4

In FT8 screen (left pane):

- Tap the **Preset** dropdown (shows current frequency/mode)
- Select an FT4 frequency to switch to FT4
- Select an FT8 frequency to switch back

In Panadapter screen:

- Tap the **Band preset dropdown** (top left)
- Some bands have both FT8 and FT4 frequencies listed
- Tap the FT4 variant to switch

Your **settings are sticky** — when you switch back to FT8 or FT4, the panadapter remembers your last frequency, bandwidth, and filter settings for each mode.

The **decode list and pileup are cleared** on the switch (v1.3.3). The two modes use different slot lengths, so stations decoded under the old timing describe a band the new mode cannot hear — and leaving them on screen meant you could tap one and try to work a station that was no longer there.

5.3. Modes of Transmission

5.0.1. Reply to a CQ

In FT8 view, tap a CQ row in the decode list. A confirmation modal appears:

```
type: panel
title: Confirm FT8 Transmission
row: K9ZZ EN52 -07 2138 Hz
row: W1AW FN31 -12 1406 Hz <- the row you picked
row: SV1ENG JN37 -09 1869 Hz
row: TX1: W1AW OZ1LAV J045
buttons: Cancel!, Auto Pounce, Transmit+
note: dim | drag up or down the list to move the highlight before you lift your finger
note: amber | Transmit sends this message once; Auto Pounce runs the whole exchange for
```

- **Transmit** (green) — send this one message on the next correct slot
- **Auto Pounce** (blue) — handle the entire exchange automatically (TX1 → wait for report → TX2 → wait for RR73 → TX3 73)
- **▲ / ▼ Nudge** — move the target to the row above or below, without closing the modal and redoing the selection gesture
- **Cancel** — abort

Transmit is intelligent (v1.3.0) — it builds the correct *next* message from what that station last sent, exactly like a WSJT-X double-click: their CQ → your grid (or your report, with Skip TX1 on), their grid → your report, their report → R+your report, their R-report → RR73, their RR73/73 → 73. You can run a whole QSO one Transmit tap at a time — and sending the closing RR73/73 **logs the QSO to ADIF** just like an automatic contact. Auto Pounce is offered on any first reply; once you're mid-exchange with a station, its rows offer Transmit only.

A quick tap is enough — you do not need to hold a row before releasing. Hold-and-drag still works for selecting across rows in a busy list.

The reply follows **correct FT8/FT4 parity** — if you're replying to an even slot, you transmit on the odd slot, and vice versa. For FT4 the countdown timer correctly counts down in 7.5-second slot increments, not 15-second FT8 ones.

Skip TX1 (faster pounce). With **Skip TX1** enabled in the Filter modal, pouncing a station opens with your signal report straight away instead of the grid exchange — saving one round trip. If the station has already dropped out of the decode list, it falls back to the normal grid exchange automatically.

If your target is working someone else, the panadapter holds instead of keying up over their exchange — the status shows "working *call* - waiting" with a **TAP TO CANCEL** line. Waiting costs nothing (a hold doesn't count toward the timeout), but if you'd rather move on, tap the status to cancel the pounce and pick a different station; the abandoned exchange stays resumable for a few minutes via the resume prompt.

Working a pile-up

When you call CQ (or work a busy run), more than one station may answer at once — and a caller who replies while you're mid-QSO with someone else used to vanish from the live decode list as soon as they stopped transmitting. They are now kept in a **Pileup** list so you don't lose them:

- Whenever one or more stations are waiting, the **ADIF-log** button on the FT8 screen becomes a **Pileup** button in a distinct colour, and reverts once the list empties.
- Tap **Pileup** to see everyone who has called you and isn't worked yet.
- **Hold the button to open the ADIF log** — the log stays reachable even while the button reads "Pileup" (a one-time hint appears the first time it flips).

- Tap a station in the list to work them (the same confirmation modal as a decode-list tap), or tap the small ✕ to dismiss them without working them. The reply is the correct **next** message for that station, built from whatever they actually last transmitted — usually a signal report for someone who has just called you, but an R+report if they came back later with a report of their own (v1.3.2; the same laddering as tapping a decode-list row).
- A station is removed from the list automatically once you start a QSO with them, and a just-completed contact's trailing 73 can't put them back.
- Stations you've worked before still appear in the pileup unless **Exclude worked-before** is checked — the pileup follows the same rule as the auto-answer.

The pile-up tracker never transmits on its own — it only remembers callers; you choose who to work. If you'd rather it *did*, check **Auto-work pileup** in the Filter modal: the strongest waiting caller is pounced automatically when your current QSO completes — or immediately, if you enable it with callers already waiting and nothing else in progress. It carries the same unattended-TX warning as the robot.

5.2. Call CQ

Tap the **Call CQ** button. A modal opens:

```
type: panel
title: CQ Messages (check the active)
row: [x] CQ OZ1LAV J065
row: [ ] CQ DX OZ1LAV J065
row: [ ] CQ POTA OZ1LAV J065
buttons: Cancel!, + call grid, Save+
note: dim | CQ stop and Listen sit top-right and apply on the tap - no Save needed
```

Choose a preset (or edit/save a new one), then tap **Transmit**. The QMX starts calling CQ and listening for replies.

CQ tone selection — the panadapter automatically picks a quiet frequency (6.25 Hz tone spacing, 200–2800 Hz audio range, no other stations nearby). If your chosen tone gets busy during a QSO, the panadapter **auto-relocates to the nearest clear frequency** to avoid stepping on other stations.

CQ auto-stop — by default the panadapter keeps calling until someone answers. If you'd rather call a few times and then pause (a common courtesy on a quiet band), long-press **Call CQ** and tap the **CQ stop** button at the top-right of the preset editor: it cycles through never / 1 / 2 / 3 / 4 / 5 / 10 calls and applies immediately, no Save needed. While calling, the TX status shows the progress ("call 2 of 4"); after the last unanswered call the panadapter listens through one more receive slot (an answer to your final call still starts the QSO normally), then stops and goes idle. Applies to every CQ run, including the automatic resume after a completed or timed-out QSO — each fresh CQ sequence starts the count over.

Listening slot - while you are transmitting you are deaf to your own time window, so the occupancy picture for the window you transmit in is the one that goes stale. The **Listen** button in the preset editor (under **CQ stop**) can spend one slot receiving after every 3, 5 or 10 calls. Off by default, because it changes your on-air cadence, and like CQ stop it applies on the tap with no Save needed.

5.3. Auto-Reply (Robot Mode)

⚠ **Requires explicit checkbox in the Filter modal** to enable.

When robot mode is on and you're idle, the panadapter scans every FT8 decode for CQ callers matching your filters, picks the highest-priority match (Strongest SNR, Weakest SNR, or Most distant grid — your choice), and starts a full QSO:

1. **TX1** — send your call, grid
2. **RX** — wait for their report
3. **TX2** — send their report + your call back
4. **RX** — wait for RR73 or 73
5. **TX3** — send 73 or RR73 (exchange complete)
6. **Log** — ADIF entry created, move to next CQ

A busy pick is abandoned, not waited for (Roy KI0ER's reasoning adopted verbatim): when *you* pounce on a station that turns out to be mid-QSO with someone else, the Tab5 politely holds — a deliberate pounce means you want *that* station. But the robot picked its target off a list, so when its pick engages a third station the robot **moves on to a different CQ caller** instead of idling through someone else's QSO. No grey-list strike: busy is not unresponsive.

Each QSO takes **~90 seconds** (6 FT8 slots × 15 s/slot). If a station doesn't respond in 4 slots, the panadapter times out and resumes scanning CQ.

Important: Robot mode **transmits on the air unattended**. Never enable it unless:

- Your station is physically attended
- Your filters are tested and correct
- Your antenna/SWR is known good
- Your QMX power is set appropriately

A permanent on-screen warning appears whenever robot mode is available.

5.4. FT8 Simulation Mode (Practice QSOs)

 **For practice only** — no real stations involved, radio never keys up. Since v1.3.0 the simulator needs **no QMX connected at all** — no radio, no antenna, zero RF.

Enable **FT8 Simulation Mode** in the settings drawer to practice everything: manual step-by-step Transmit, Auto Pounce, CQ-runs, pileups, and Field Day exchanges. Useful for:

- Learning the full FT8 exchange sequence
- Testing your setup without risking interference
- Verifying ADIF logging works correctly
- Practicing the pileup tools on a genuine pileup

How it works:

- **Six phantom stations** (three US, three DX) call CQ on their own tones — every message is real FT8, synthesized to actual GFSK audio and decoded through the same receive pipeline real RF uses
- Tap a CQ to pounce (auto or fully manual — they answer either), or **Call CQ** yourself and **four phantoms answer at once**, building a real pileup
- Phantoms are **patient like real operators**: each repeats its message every cycle, up to four times, before giving up and going back to CQing; one you're working stops CQing; one you've worked stops answering your CQs (toggle sim off/on to reset)
- Their replies match **what you actually transmitted** — grid gets a report, a report gets a roger, RR73 gets a courtesy 73
- The **Fast pounce** toggle is honoured, so you can watch what it changes: decodes surface just before the slot boundary with it on, just after with it off
- Swiping to the Panadapter and back clears the phantom rows and pileup for a fresh session, and **turning simulation mode off also clears them** (v1.3.3) — phantom stations no longer linger in a list that is supposed to be real, where they were still tappable

!!! note "Fixed in v1.3.3" With **Fast pounce** turned *off* — which is the default — the phantoms never answered at all, so every practice pounce simply timed out. If you tried the simulator before v1.3.3 and concluded the phantom stations were ignoring you, that was this, not you.

Visual indicator: When simulation mode is active, a **10 px red border pulses around the entire screen** (breathing red frame). This is your visual reminder that you're in practice mode — if the red frame is gone, simulation is off and real stations are in play.

Important:

- The QMX is **never keyed** in simulation mode, no matter what
- QSOs are logged as real ADIF entries — deliberately, so the logging/upload paths get exercised too. When you're done, the ADIF viewer shows a "**Del N test**" button (only while practice contacts exist — they're recognized by their missing frequency): two taps deletes them all
- All other features (panadapter, web UI, settings) work normally

5.5. ARRL Field Day Mode

During [ARRL Field Day](#), enable **Field Day mode** in the settings:

- **Mode** — on/off
- **Class** — your transmitter class (1–2 kW)
- **Section** — your ARRL section

When FD mode is active:

- **CQ message changes** to CQ FD (replaces any other modifier)
- **Exchange message** includes your class and section (e.g., 5B WCF = class 5, section WCF)
- **ADIF record** logs `CONTEST_ID=ARRL-FD`, your section, and their section

The full FD exchange is automatic — no manual mode switching needed.

5.6. Message Status

The FT8 left pane shows a **status label** indicating what's happening:

Status	Meaning
ACTIVE (red)	Transmitting right now
ARMED (amber)	Ready to transmit next slot
QSO Complete (green)	Exchange finished, logged to ADIF
QSO Timeout (orange)	No response after 4 slots, exchange aborted
(dim white)	Idle, no active QSO

Tap the status label to **abort** the current QSO (only works if ARMED or ACTIVE; once COMPLETE, it's logged).

Resume after timeout — if a QSO times out because the partner faded, and they come back within ~5 minutes calling you, the exchange **resumes where it left off** automatically (or tap their row to resume manually) instead of restarting from scratch.

If they never heard your final (v1.3.4) — a partner who does not decode your closing 73/RR73 keeps sending you their report, waiting for it. The Tab5 now notices: if the station just worked comes back with a report rather than RR73/73/RRR, the final is sent again, up to three times within four minutes, *before* anything else can start a new contact. The QSO is not logged a second time. Taking over by hand no longer produces a duplicate entry either — the same callsign on the same band inside ten minutes is recognised as the same contact.

5.7. Power & SWR Readout

After each transmit burst, the status bar briefly shows:

Last TX: 5.2W SWRx1.25 [N=79]

- **5.2W** — average output power measured via QMX PC; CAT command
- **SWRx1.25** — SWR measured via QMX SW; CAT command (only valid during TX)
- **[N=79]** — number of symbols transmitted
 - FT8: always 79 symbols (~12.7 s at 160 ms/symbol)
 - FT4: always 105 symbols (~5.0 s at 48 ms/symbol)

These readings are **informational only** — the panadapter does not enforce limits. Monitor your antenna system independently.

5.8. CQ Presets

You can save up to 3 custom CQ messages:

1. Tap **Call CQ**
2. Tap **Edit Presets** (or long-press the active preset)
3. Type your message: callsign, modifier (optional), grid
4. Tap **Save**

Presets persist across power cycles. Common modifiers:

- **DX** — calling DX only
- **POTA** — Parks on the Air activation
- **SOTA** — Summits on the Air activation
- *(blank)* — standard CQ

The preset editor's top-right **CQ stop** button sets the CQ auto-stop limit (see [Call CQ](#) above) — it cycles never / 1–5 / 10 and applies on tap, independent of Save/Cancel.

5.9. Frequency & Tone Control

Your transmit tone is chosen for you by default — the nearest clear 50 Hz slot, scanned against the stations currently decoded. You can see it, move it, and from v1.3.4 pin it.

The TX tone button is in the FT8 left pane, to the right of the **TXCQ** parity button, and always shows a number (1500 Hz until you change it). Tap it to open the picker.

The mini occupancy strip sits directly under the slot countdown in the same pane: the same 50 Hz grid and the same colours as the picker's full-size strip, so where the band is busy — and where you are in it — is answerable at a glance without opening anything.

Both time windows, always (asked for by Roy K10ER). The strip is **two rows — EVEN above, ODD below**, marked E and O in the same blue/orange the slot countdown uses. Two stations only collide if they transmit in the *same* window, and only you know which window you are about to pounce into — so both pictures are on screen **before** you choose, not after a transmission has fixed your window. Your white marker sits on your own window's row once one is locked (both rows until then), and your partner's pink sits in *their* window. The picker's full-size strip is split the same way, and its verdict says where your pick stands: "*Clear in EVEN — busy in ODD*".

In the picker:

Control	What it does
Occupancy strip	The whole 200-2800 Hz window as 52 slots. Green free, red occupied, white you, pink your QSO partner
Touch and drag	Drag along the strip to pick a slot. The bar turns grey and follows your finger, the readout tracks it live, and it commits when you lift off
-50 / +50	Nudge one slot at a time
Find clear slot	Jumps to the nearest free slot, scanning outward from where you are
TX Hold	Pins the tone: every CQ and every reply goes out on it. See below
Apply nnnn Hz	Commits the tone and the hold setting

The readout states in words whether your chosen slot is clear or occupied, and lists the nearest free slots as numbers.

It applies **between** bursts. With a burst on the air, Apply refuses and says to try again after it. Slot parity is untouched, so moving your tone mid-QSO does not disturb the exchange — your partner tracks the slot, not the frequency. This is the same freedom WSJT-X gives you, and it is the way out from under a station that has landed on top of you.

TX Hold is WSJT-X's "Hold Tx Freq". With it **off** — the default — each transmission takes the nearest clear slot, and a CQ that gets clashed relocates itself on the next cycle. With it **on**, the tone you picked is the tone used for everything, a clash is reported but never acted on, and nothing moves you off the slot you chose. The line under the checkbox says which of the two you are getting. Both the tone and the hold setting survive a power cycle.

!!! note "The strip shows decoded stations, not raw spectrum" A station too weak to decode will not appear as occupied, and an all-grey strip means nothing has been heard yet rather than "the band is clear".

!!! note "Occupancy is per time window" Two stations only collide if they transmit in the *same* slot, so a tone busy in the odd window may be completely free for you in the even one. The strip accounts for this whenever your own transmit window is known — that is, once a reply or a CQ is armed, since a reply inherits the opposite of your partner's slot and a CQ carries your `TXCQ EVEN/ODD` choice. With `TXCQ ANY` and nothing armed there is nothing to work from, so both windows are shown combined. When the window *is* known, the free-slot line names it.

Waiting for a busy station

On a crowded band several stations answer the same CQ and the caller works one of them. If that is not you, the Tab5 no longer keeps calling: while their last decoded message is addressed to somebody else, **nothing is transmitted**, and the status line shows `working <call> - waiting`. As soon as they send 73 or RR73, or call CQ again, it picks up where it left off.

This also protects the grey-list. Giving up on a station used to count against it, so a popular station could end up permanently skipped by the robot and Auto-work-pileup for no reason other than being busy. A wait is not a failed attempt. The wait is capped at about six minutes so a station that vanishes mid-exchange still times out normally.

To tune to a different frequency while CQ is running:

1. Tap the **Freq** label on the top bar
2. Enter a new frequency
3. The CQ continues on the new frequency next slot

5.10. ADIF Logging

Every completed QSO is **automatically logged to ADIF** on the Tab5's internal storage:

- **Callsign**, grid, report (SNR), time (UTC)

- **Frequency**, mode (FT8)
- **Duration** (QSO start to finish)
- **Operator** (your callsign)

Download the log via the web UI (**QSO Logs** menu → **ADIF download** ↓) or Settings → ADIF Log.

5.11. Upload to QRZ, eQSL & LoTW

Via the web UI:

1. Open the **QSO Logs** menu in the bottom bar and click **QRZ upload** ↑, **eQSL upload** ↑, or **LoTW setup** (reads **LoTW** ↑ once configured)
2. Enter your API key (QRZ), username/password (eQSL), or run the guided certificate setup (LoTW) when first prompted — credentials are saved for future sessions
3. Click again to upload

See [Web UI → LoTW Upload](#) for the LoTW certificate setup details.

Logs are batched — each upload session records which QSOs have been sent, so re-running skips already-submitted entries.

Uploads work **while FT8 or FT4 is actively running** — the panadapter briefly steps the FFT and SD-archive activity aside for the duration of the HTTPS transfer, then resumes automatically. You typically miss one FT8 slot and won't notice. A progress result is shown once the upload completes.

5.12. Troubleshooting

"QMX not responding to TX command"

- Check USB cable (must be data cable, not charge-only)
- Verify QMX is in the correct mode (USB/LSB/CW/DiGi, not AM)
- Try a manual TX; command via the web UI's CAT tab

"⚠ FREQ BUSY warning, but no other station is there"

- The clash detector reserves a ± 50 Hz guard band around each decoded station, so it flags a neighbour that is close rather than exactly on you
- It counts only stations **in your own transmit window** (it used to count both windows, so it could warn about a station that could never collide with you; Roy KI0ER caught it)

- The warning names the frequency. Tap **TX nnnn Hz** and either **Find clear slot** or drag to a green slot on the occupancy strip
- Remember the strip only knows about stations it has *decoded* — a very weak one will not show

"QSO timeout — no response"

- The called station didn't hear you (too weak, bad timing, etc.)
- Try a different station, or switch to manual mode and check levels first
- See [Troubleshooting](#) for more

Next: Set up [Time Sync](#) for accurate FT8 timing, or explore the [Web UI](#).

The Tab5 transmits FT8 via the QMX's `TA<freq>; CAT` command — no PC audio path, no WSJT-X. The QMX does all DDS synthesis and envelope shaping; the Tab5 sends the 79 tone-frequency commands at 160 ms cadence, bracketed by `TX; / TA0; / RX;`.

Replying to a station

1. In the decode list, **hold your finger on a row** for ~250 ms. A dim highlight appears after ~80 ms so you can see which row you're targeting. List scroll locks once the gate fires; drag up or down to land on the right row.
2. **Lift** — a confirmation modal shows the exact message that will go on air, the audio frequency, and the target slot parity.
3. Tap **Auto Pounce** to hand the full QSO to the auto-engine, or **Transmit** for a single manual message.
4. Tap **Cancel** (in the modal, or the armed indicator in the left pane) to disarm without transmitting.

Transmit is intelligent (v1.3.0): it builds the correct *next* message for that station from what they last sent — the same semantics as a WSJT-X double-click. Their CQ → your grid (or your report directly, if **Skip TX1** is on); their grid → your report; their report → R+your report; their R-report → RR73; their RR73/73 → 73. The report value is always your live measurement of their signal. You can walk an entire QSO step by step with nothing but Transmit taps — and when you send the closing RR73/73, the QSO **logs to ADIF** exactly like an auto-engine contact. Auto Pounce is offered on any first reply; mid-QSO rows get Transmit only.

Slot parity is set automatically — if you heard them on an EVEN slot, your reply goes on ODD so they're listening when you transmit.

The auto-engine works the full exchange: TX1 (grid) → wait for their report → TX2 (R+report) → wait for RR73/73 → TX3 (73) → DONE. At every step it re-sends the current message for up to 4 consecutive slots if the other station doesn't respond. If no reply comes after 4 slots, the QSO times out (orange status, tap to clear).

Skip TX1 (faster pounce). With **Skip TX1** enabled in the Filter editor, a pounce opens with your signal report immediately instead of the grid exchange — saving one round trip. If the station has already aged out of the decode list, it falls back to the normal grid TX1 automatically.

Working a pile-up

When you call CQ or work a run, more than one station may answer at once — and a caller who replies while you're mid-QSO with someone else used to vanish from the live decode list once they stopped transmitting. They're now held in a **Pileup** list so you don't lose them:

- Whenever callers are waiting, the **ADIF-log** button on the FT8 screen becomes a **Pileup** button in a distinct colour, reverting once the list empties.
- Tap **Pileup** to see everyone who has called you and isn't worked yet. Tap a station to work them (the same confirmation modal as a decode-list tap), or tap the ✕ to dismiss one.
- **Hold the button to open the ADIF log** — the log is always reachable this way, even while the button reads "Pileup" (v1.3.0; a one-time hint appears the first time the button flips).
- A station is removed from the list automatically once you start a QSO with them, and a just-completed contact's trailing 73 can't put them back.
- Working a caller from the pileup sends the correct *next* message for that station, built from whatever they actually last transmitted — the same laddering as tapping a decode-list row (v1.3.2). Previously it always opened with a signal report, which could never produce the R+report a station needs when they come back minutes later with a report of their own.
- Worked-before stations appear in the pileup unless **Exclude worked-before** is checked — the pileup follows the same rule as the auto-answer, so dupes you're willing to work stay visible.

The tracker never transmits on its own — it only remembers callers; you choose who to work. If you'd rather it *did* transmit, check **Auto-work pileup** in the Filter editor: when your current QSO completes (or immediately, if you check it with callers already waiting and nothing else going on), the strongest waiting caller is pounced automatically, draining the pile one contact at a time. It carries the same unattended-TX warning as the robot.

Calling CQ — CQ-run mode

Tap **Call CQ**. No confirmation modal. The engine:

1. Scans the current decode list for occupied 50 Hz audio bins.
2. Picks the nearest unoccupied bin to 1500 Hz (standard FT8 sub-band centre).
3. Arms the CQ on the matching slot parity and waits for the boundary.

From there it's fully automatic:

- The opposite-parity slot is decoded while CQ runs so replies are never missed.
- The moment a station replies with your callsign, CQing stops and the exchange starts automatically — best-SNR caller chosen if multiple stations answer simultaneously.
- After the exchange completes (RR73 → 73 → logged), CQ resumes on the same frequency.
- A mid-exchange timeout also resumes CQ rather than dropping the frequency.
- While CQ-run is active, other stations' cq rows are hidden so replies to you stand out.

Tap **Cancel** in the TX status bar at any time to stop.

Reply filter

Tap **Filter** in the left pane to open the filter editor. Controls which stations CQ-run auto-answers and which rows appear in the decode list.

- **Include 1 / Include 2** — if either field has text, only messages containing one of its terms are eligible. Space- or comma-separated (e.g. POTA SOTA or JA, VK), matched against the *whole* decoded message text so POTA/SOTA tags, grid squares, country prefixes, /P suffixes etc. all work.
- **Exclude 1 / Exclude 2** — messages containing any of these terms are skipped even if they'd otherwise match.
- **Exclude plain CQ callers** — hides bare cq ... rows so only replies and exchanges remain visible.
- **Exclude worked-before** — hides callsigns already worked **on the current band** (per-band, from your ADIF log) from the list and from CQ-run auto-replies; the same station on a different band is treated as not worked.
- **Skip TX1** — when you pounce a station, open with your signal report instead of the grid exchange for a quicker QSO (falls back to the grid exchange if the station has aged out of the decode list).

- **Allow grey-listing** — off by default. When enabled, a station that times out two of your pounces in a row is set aside: the robot and Auto-work-pileup skip it, its decode row turns violet, and tapping it offers to clear it rather than opening the TX dialog. Useful on a busy band where one station simply never comes back. The list lives in RAM only and is forgotten at power-off.

Tap **Save** to persist (NVS) and apply immediately.

Auto-answer CQ (robot)

⚠ Transmits unattended — never leave it running unsupervised. When enabled, the robot picks a CQ caller every slot (filtered the same way as above, plus a worked-before skip) and runs the full exchange itself — no per-QSO confirmation, no tap required. Pick a **Priority**: Strongest signal, Weakest signal, or Most distant grid. Same TX1→report→RR73→73→ADIF-log flow as a manually-tapped reply; you just aren't the one tapping. You remain responsible for everything it transmits under your callsign, same as any other unattended digital-mode software.

ARRL Field Day mode

A checkbox in the same Filter modal as above (with Class/Section text fields next to it) switches the FT8 exchange from grid/signal-report to ARRL Field Day's class+section format — e.g. 16A EMA instead of a grid square, using the standard WA9XYZ KA1ABC R 16A EMA-style FT8 message type (the same one WSJT-X uses for FD). Pounce and CQ-run both follow the convention automatically: the initial grid-exchange message is unchanged, but the report-equivalent step carries class+section instead, with the receiving side echoing it back R-prefixed.

While the mode is on, **Call CQ** automatically tags your CQ message CQ FD <call> <grid> (the same "CQ modifier" mechanism as CQ POTA/CQ DX) so other Field Day stations know to expect this exchange instead of a normal report — this overrides any other modifier on the active CQ preset for as long as the mode is enabled. The long-press CQ preset editor reflects this: while Field Day mode is on, the three presets are shown dimmed (their own modifier doesn't matter right now) and a live preview line shows exactly what will be transmitted.

Completed Field Day QSOs log the standard ADIF contest fields (see the table below) alongside the usual call/freq/time fields, so they import cleanly into contest-logging software.

FT8 Simulation mode

A "**FT8 Simulation Mode**" checkbox in the FT8 settings drawer (FT8 screen only) lets you practice everything — manual step-by-step Transmit, Auto Pounce, CQ-runs, pileups, and Field Day exchanges — with **no real station, no antenna, and no QMX connected at all** (v1.3.0; previously the radio had to be attached even though it was never keyed).

Six phantom stations (three US, three DX) call CQ on their own tones. Each phantom message is a real FT8 message, synthesized to actual GFSK audio and decoded through the same on-device receive pipeline real RF goes through — what lands in the decode list genuinely round-tripped the receiver. The phantoms behave like real operators:

- Tap a CQ to pounce (auto or fully manual — they answer either), or **Call CQ** yourself and **four of them answer at once**, building a genuine pileup to practice the pileup tools on.
- They're **patient**: each message repeats every cycle, up to four times, until you respond — then they give up and go back to CQing. A phantom you're mid-QSO with stops CQing; one you've worked stops answering your CQs for the session (toggle sim off/on to reset).
- Their replies match **what you actually transmitted** — grid gets a report back, a report gets a roger, RR73 gets a courtesy 73.
- The **Fast pounce** toggle (below) is honoured: with it ON, phantom messages surface just before the slot boundary; with it OFF, just after — so you can see exactly what the toggle changes.
- Swiping to the Panadapter and back clears the phantom rows and pileup for a fresh session.

While simulation mode is on, a **breathing red border** frames the whole screen as an unmissable reminder that nothing transmitted right now is real — the hard interlock lives in firmware (every CAT command that would key the radio is skipped, logged instead), not just in the UI. Completed simulated QSOs log to the same ADIF file as real ones — deliberately, so the logging/upload paths get exercised too. When you're done practicing, the ADIF viewer shows a "**Del N test**" button (only while simulation records exist — they're recognizable by their missing frequency): two taps wipes every practice contact from the log.

TX status indicator

The left pane shows a persistent status line below the slot countdown:

Colour	Meaning
Red	TRANSMITTING: <message> — burst in progress, with your audio tone on its own line ; tap to abort
Amber	TX armed: <message> then nnnn Hz → EVEN/ODD, ~Ns — waiting for slot; tap to cancel
Red-orange  FREQ BUSY	Your tone is occupied (± 50 Hz guard), and the warning names the frequency so you can act on it. During CQ-run this self-heals — the next cycle hops to the nearest clear tone automatically. Mid-exchange you can now move it yourself: see TX audio frequency below
Amber, working <call> - waiting + TAP TO CANCEL	The station you are calling is mid-exchange with somebody else. Nothing is transmitted until they sign off or call CQ again — or tap to cancel the pounce and work someone else (v1.3.5). See Waiting for a busy station below
Green	QSO complete
Orange	QSO timed out — tap to clear
Dim white	FT8 engine status passthrough (capturing / decoding / symbol count / ...)

TX audio frequency

Your transmit tone is chosen automatically — the nearest clear 50 Hz slot to 1500 Hz, scanned against the stations currently decoded. From v1.3.3 you can both **see** it and **change** it.

The **TX nnnn Hz** button in the FT8 left pane always shows it — to the right of the txcq parity button — and tapping it opens the picker. A **mini occupancy strip** under the slot countdown shows the same picture at a glance. (Before v1.3.4 this was a chip that appeared only while a CQ or QSO was running, and the tone was also repeated on the TX status line.)

Control	What it does
Occupancy strip	The whole 200-2800 Hz window as 52 slots. Green free, red occupied, white you, pink your QSO partner
Touch and drag	Pick a slot by dragging along the strip. The bar goes grey and follows your finger, the readout tracks it live, and it commits when you lift off
-50 / +50	Nudge one slot at a time
Find clear slot	Scans outward from where you are and jumps to the nearest free slot
Apply nnnn Hz	Sends it to the radio

The readout also says in words whether the slot you have picked is clear or occupied, and the free slots nearest you are listed as numbers underneath.

It applies **between** bursts. If a burst is on the air, Apply refuses and tells you to try again after it — the same rule WSJT-X operators are used to. Slot parity is untouched, so moving your tone mid-QSO does not disturb the exchange; your partner tracks the slot, not the frequency.

The strip shows decoded stations, not raw spectrum. A station too weak to decode will not show as occupied, and an all-grey strip means nothing has been heard yet rather than "the band is clear".

Waiting for a busy station

On a crowded band several stations answer the same CQ and the caller works one of them. If that is not you, the Tab5 no longer keeps calling: while their last decoded message is addressed to somebody else, **nothing is transmitted**. The status line shows `working <call> - waiting`. As soon as they send 73 or RR73, or call CQ again, it picks up where it left off.

You are not committed to the wait (v1.3.5, Roy K10ER's report): the status line carries a **TAP TO CANCEL** line during the hold, and tapping it drops the pounce so you are free to work anyone else. The abandoned exchange stays resumable for a few minutes in case the station frees up and you want back in.

This also protects the grey-list. Giving up on a station used to count against it, so a popular station could end up permanently skipped by the robot and Auto-work-pileup for no reason other than being busy. A wait is not a failed attempt. The wait is capped at about six minutes so a station that vanishes mid-exchange still times out normally.

QSO override buttons

During an active auto-QSO exchange (any state between first reply and final 73), three buttons appear in the left pane:

Button	What it does
Re-send / <field> (amber)	Re-arms the current outgoing message immediately. The label shows what will go out — e.g. Re-send / JO45 when waiting for their report, Re-send / -07 when waiting for RR73
RR73 (blue)	Skips straight to RR73, bypassing the report step
73 (green)	Fires the 73 sign-off and closes the QSO immediately

These are deliberate operator nudges for busy-band edge cases where the auto-engine falls a slot behind or you can see the exchange is further along than the state machine knows. The auto-engine handles the normal case; these exist for when a quick nudge is faster than waiting through the 4-slot retry cycle.

TX power / SWR readout

After each burst the Tab5 queries `PC;/SW;` for instantaneous forward power and SWR and shows the result briefly in the status line: `Last TX: X.XW SWRx.xx [Ns]`. If `SWR > 4.0` (indicating the QMX SWR-protection latch tripped), the firmware automatically cycles `TX;` / `150 ms / RX;` to clear the latch so the radio is ready for the next TX slot without operator intervention.

SWR protection

Reading the SWR is one thing; **acting** on it is another. Set a limit in **Radio** → **SWR protection** — **Off, 2.0, 2.5, 3.0** or **4.0 : 1**, defaulting to **3.0:1** — and a transmission that reaches it stops, with the transmitter **latched off** until you clear it by tapping the red warning on the FT8 screen.

An FT8 burst is nearly **thirteen seconds of continuous key-down**, so a disconnected antenna, a wrong-band antenna or a damaged feedline has real time to do damage. 3.0:1 is high enough not to trip on a merely mediocre match and low enough to catch those.

FT8 and FT4 differ, on purpose. In FT8 the SWR is sampled part-way through and the burst is **cut short**. In FT4 the check runs **after** the burst, so that one burst completes and every later one is blocked — FT4 symbols are 48 ms and a control-link query takes about 50 ms, so asking mid-burst would disturb the very transmission it is protecting. A reading only counts if there is real power behind it; the radio can report a meaningless ratio when the amplifier is not actually loaded.

The latch is deliberately sticky. A bad antenna does not repair itself, and resuming automatically would just transmit into the same fault on the next slot.

Activation (POTA / SOTA)

Start an activation in **Station** → **Activation**, pick **POTA** or **SOTA**, and enter the reference (`DL-0123, OZ/SJ-001`). From then on **every logged contact carries it automatically** — written as the `ADIF MY_SIG / MY_SIG_INFO` fields as the record is created, so no contact can be logged without it by forgetting a step.

The panel shows your **contact count against the threshold** — 10 for POTA, 4 for SOTA — read from the log itself rather than from a counter that could drift.

Chases are tagged too. If you work a station the panadapter has already seen spotted, their reference is recorded as `SIG / SIG_INFO`, so a chase is logged as a chase without you typing anything.

Stopping is as prominent as starting, because the failure that actually happens is driving home with it still running and stamping the next evening's contacts with a park you left.

The session survives a reboot, but is deliberately **not** part of the config backup — a backup restored weeks later would otherwise start stamping QSOs with an old activation.

Uploading just that park: the ADIF download takes an optional reference, so you can export one activation's contacts rather than your whole log. In the web UI it is on the QSO Logs menu.

CQ message presets

Long-press the **Call CQ** button to open the preset editor. Three message slots with radio buttons — check the active one. `A + <call> <grid>` quick-insert appends your identity. Standard CQ constructions (`CQ DX OZ1LAV J065FR, CQ POTA ...`) and ≤ 13 -char free text both encode via the general `ft8_lib` encoder. Presets persist to NVS. The Call CQ button label shows the selected message; a short tap transmits it.

CQ auto-stop (v1.3.5, Don WB0LQW's "I usually send CQ 2-4 times and then pause"). The editor's top-right **CQ stop** button cycles `never / 1 / 2 / 3 / 4 / 5 / 10` calls and applies the moment you tap it — no Save needed. While calling, the TX status shows the counter live ("call 2 of 4"). After the last unanswered call the Tab5 listens through one more receive slot — an answer to your final call still starts the QSO normally — then stops and goes idle. The limit applies to every CQ run, including the automatic resume after a completed or timed-out contact; each fresh sequence starts the count over. Persists across power cycles and travels in the config backup.

QSO logging (ADIF)

Every completed FT8 QSO — pounce or CQ-run — is automatically written to an ADIF v3.1.4 file at `/spiffs/qso.adf` on the Tab5's internal flash. The log survives reboots and re-flashes.

Download. The web UI bottom bar shows the **QSO Logs** menu once the first QSO is logged. **ADIF download** ↓ fetches `qso.adif` for import into any logging software (WSJT-X, Log4OM, DXKeeper, ...) or for POTA.app, which has no upload API (see below); **View / edit log** opens it as a sortable table with per-record delete and Delete-all — see [Web UI](#).

View and edit on the Tab5. The **ADIF Log** button on the FT8 screen (long-press always works, even while it reads "Pileup") opens the on-device viewer: a Today/All filter with a POTA activation counter (the title turns green at 10 QSOs today), long-press a row to delete that single record, and — new in v1.3.5 — **Delete all**, next to Close: the first tap arms it and shows the live count ("ALL 34?"), a second tap within five seconds erases the log, waiting disarms it. Clearing the log (from either the Tab5 or the browser) also resets the QRZ/eQSL/LoTW upload positions, so QSOs logged afterwards upload normally. The clear-first workflow is the practical POTA tool: start the activation with an empty log and the ADIF at the end is exactly what you submit.

Upload to QRZ Logbook / eQSL — directly from the Tab5. Two more buttons appear next to the ADIF download link once you've logged a QSO: **"QRZ ↑"** and **"eQSL ↑"**. Tap either the first time and it prompts for credentials (QRZ: API key from *Logbook Data* → *API Key* on qrz.com; eQSL: your username and password — eQSL has no API-key scheme) and saves them on the Tab5, not just in the browser. Every tap after that uploads everything logged since the last successful upload — no need to re-enter credentials, and no risk of duplicate uploads, since the Tab5 tracks how far it's gotten into the log. If a record is rejected (bad credentials, quota, etc.) the run stops and reports the reason rather than skipping past it; fix the cause and tap again to resume from where it left off. eQSL accepts a whole batch of QSOs per request; QRZ's API takes one at a time, so a big log takes one HTTP round trip per QSO.

Upload to ARRL LoTW — also directly from the Tab5. The Tab5 signs your QSOs on-device with your own LoTW callsign certificate, so no TQSL and no PC are involved. The bottom bar shows "**LoTW setup**" until it is configured, then "**LoTW ↑**".

Setup is a two-page guided flow. Page one points you at ARRL's own "Save the Callsign Certificate" instructions — you export a .p12 file from TQSL, which most people did once, years ago. Page two takes that file, its password, and your DXCC entity number:

Field	Notes
.p12 file + password	Parsed in your browser , not on the Tab5 — the password never reaches the device. Only the certificate and key are sent
DXCC entity number	Required. The same one your TQSL station location uses (Denmark = 221, USA = 291)
CQ zone / ITU zone	Optional
US state / county	US stations only (v1.3.3). Without them your QSOs earn no Worked All States and no county credit — for you or for the stations you work. The county is the name on its own (Arlington), not VA, Arlington

Every tap of **LoTW ↑** afterwards signs and uploads everything logged since the last successful upload. Ctrl-click **LoTW ↑** to re-run setup — a certificate is typically valid three years. Re-importing the *same* certificate no longer re-uploads your whole log; only an actually-changed certificate resets the upload position, since a new key means everything has to be re-signed.

Uploads are queued at ARRL's end. If a QSO does not appear immediately, check [the LoTW queue status](#) before assuming a problem — the queue has run hours behind at busy times. LoTW rejects a malformed file at upload time, so anything that reaches the queue was signed correctly.

POTA.app has no upload API at all (browser login or email only), so use the ADIF download above for that.

Fields in each record:

ADIF field	Content
CALL	Their callsign
FREQ	Dial frequency in MHz (3 d.p., e.g. 14.074)
BAND	Amateur band (e.g. 20M)
MODE	FT8
SUBMODE	FT8 (required by LoTW TQSL and eQSL for digital mode credit)
RST_SENT	Our SNR estimate (e.g. -07). Omitted entirely if no report was exchanged — writing a placeholder 599 into an FT8 log, as versions before v1.3.4 did, fabricates a measurement that then gets uploaded to QRZ/eQSL/LoTW
RST_RCVD	Signal report received
QSO_DATE	UTC date YYYYMMDD
TIME_ON	UTC time HHMMSS
MY_CALL	Your callsign (from Identity in the drawer)
MY_GRIDSQUARE	Your grid
GRIDSQUARE	Their grid (from the decoded FT8 message)
CONTEST_ID, STX_STRING, SRX_STRING, ARRL_SECT, MY_ARRL_SECT	Field Day mode only: contest ID ARRL-FD, your/their literal <class> <section> exchange text, and their/your section alone

Clear. GET /api/adif/clear from the web UI wipes the file and resets the worked-call cache.

Set your callsign and grid in the settings drawer → **Identity** before your first QSO so they appear correctly in logged records.

6. Time sync

FT8 requires accurate UTC time — within ± 1 second of the real thing. The panadapter syncs time from multiple sources in priority order.

6.1. Time Sources (Priority Order)

1. **GPS-disciplined QMX** (auto-detected) — phase-locked to the GPS second, ~ 10 ms, works offline
2. **WiFi + SNTP** (if available) — ~ 10 ms, re-syncs every ~ 1 hour
3. **Tab5 RTC** (if set) — persists across power cycles (± 1 min accuracy)
4. **FT8/FT4-derived** — offline fallback only (ignored while GPS/SNTP is up)
5. **Manual set** — enter time manually via the settings drawer

GPS and SNTP are the two accurate sources and are used whenever present; if you're offline with neither, the panadapter falls back to the RTC (or FT8-derived / manual).

6.2. Offline (POTA / Portable)

If you're operating **without WiFi** (POTA, portable, SOTA):

1. **Set the Tab5 RTC before you leave home** (settings → Time)
2. The RTC is powered by a **supercap battery** and holds time for **30–40 hours** without power
3. When you turn the Tab5 on in the field, it reads the RTC immediately
4. Optional: if your QMX has GPS, the panadapter syncs the RTC from QMX GPS every 5 minutes

No internet needed — FT8 timing works offline.

6.3. WiFi + SNTP

When WiFi is active:

1. The panadapter connects to an SNTP server (default pool.ntp.org)
2. Gets the current UTC time
3. Sets the system clock and writes it to the Tab5 RTC
4. Checks periodically ($\sim$ hourly) and re-syncs if time has drifted

SNTP sync is **automatic** — you don't need to do anything. The bottom bar shows the current time (updates every second).

6.4. QMX GPS Time Sync (auto-detected)

If your QMX has **internal GPS** (QMX+ models often do), there is **nothing to enable** — the Tab5 detects it automatically:

1. At connect, it catches the QMX's $\overline{TM}$; seconds *flip* (the true GPS second boundary) and compares it against SNTP.
2. If they agree tightly, the QMX is flagged GPS-disciplined and the clock is **phase-locked to that second edge** (~10 ms, drift-free), not just set to the whole second. Re-locks every 5 minutes.
3. If they don't agree (a non-GPS QMX with a free-running RTC), it's used only as a low-priority offline fallback.

The verdict is remembered across reboots, so starting up away from home keeps GPS timing without having to re-detect it. A GPS-disciplined QMX shows **UTC(GPS)** in the bottom bar and is a top-tier source (as good as SNTP); a non-GPS QMX shows **UTC(QMX)** and only helps when offline.

!!! note "The label needs the radio to still be there" The remembered verdict says *this radio is GPS-disciplined*, not *GPS is keeping time right now*. With the QMX unplugged the Tab5 has no GPS of its own, so the label falls back to whatever is actually in charge — usually UTC(NTP). Reported by Don N2VGU, whose Tab5 read UTC(GPS) with the radio disconnected; the time was correct throughout, only the label was wrong.

6.5. Manual Time Set

To set time manually:

1. Swipe ← to open the settings drawer
2. Tap **Time Sync** section
3. Tap **Set Manual Time**
4. Enter hours, minutes, seconds (UTC)
5. Tap **Apply**

The time is set immediately and written to the RTC.

6.6. FT8-Derived Sync (Offline Fallback)

The panadapter can also **estimate the UTC offset** from decoded FT8/FT4 signal timing and nudge the clock:

1. Decode several messages (requires on-air activity)
2. Measure their timing relative to the slot boundary
3. Estimate the error and apply a damped correction

This runs only as an offline fallback. While SNTP or a GPS-disciplined QMX is available they are authoritative and FT8-derived sync is **ignored** — deliberately. The FT8 slot offset the device measures is dominated by $\sim 1/2$ second of one-way *receive audio latency* (QMX SDR + USB buffering), which is **not** a clock error; letting it pull the clock would actually drag your transmit timing late. So it only touches the clock when you're off-grid with no SNTP/GPS.

Most useful when: WiFi is unavailable, no GPS QMX, and your RTC has drifted.

Fine-Tune Time with "Sync Time" (FT8 Only)

In **FT8 mode**, the Filter modal includes a **"Sync Time" button** that opens an interactive time-setting panel:

1. Tap the **Filter** button (FT8 screen, left pane)
2. Tap the **Sync Time** button (bottom right of the modal)
3. A panel appears with three fields: **[HH] : [MM] : [SS]**
 - **HH / MM** (hours/minutes) — tap to edit via numpad (0–23, 0–59)
 - **SS** (seconds) — auto-syncs from FT8 signals (blue frame = actively syncing, grey = locked)
4. Tap **Apply** to write the time to the RTC and system clock

The **SS field** updates automatically from decoded FT8 messages — each decode gives a sub-second correction estimate. Tap **SS** to toggle between auto-syncing (blue) and locked (grey). While locked, seconds still count at the captured offset, so you don't lose precision after locking.

Use case: You're operating portable without WiFi, your RTC is ~ 5 seconds off, and there's on-air FT8 activity. Set HH/MM manually, let SS auto-sync to the decoded signal timing for a few seconds, lock it, and you're done — FT8 timing is now precise.

FT8-derived sync shows **SS (sub-second)** in the bottom bar when active.

6.7. Bottom Bar Time Display

The center of the bottom bar shows the current UTC time and which source is active:

Indicator	Meaning	Updates
UTC(GPS)	GPS-disciplined QMX, auto-detected, phase-locked to the GPS second (~10 ms)	Every 5 min
UTC(NTP)	WiFi + SNTP	~1 hour
UTC(FT4) / UTC(FT8)	FT4/FT8-derived offline sync	Continuous (when decoding, offline only)
UTC(RTC)	Tab5 supercap RTC	At boot
UTC(MAN)	Manual time set	On-demand
UTC(QMX)	Non-GPS QMX RTC fallback (offline only)	Every 5 min
UTC	Fallback (no sync source)	—

The suffix tells you at a glance which source is **currently in charge** (the active authority, not merely the last one that wrote the clock). A GPS-disciplined QMX (UTC(GPS)) and WiFi/SNTP (UTC(NTP)) are both accurate — if you see either, you're set. If you're off-grid you'll see UTC(FT8)/UTC(FT4) (on-air digital activity), UTC(QMX) (non-GPS QMX clock), or UTC(RTC) (the supercap RTC you set before leaving home).

6.8. Slot Timing

FT8 operates on **15-second slot boundaries** aligned to UTC. The panadapter:

1. Reads the current system time
2. Waits until the next 15-second boundary (hh:mm:00, hh:mm:15, hh:mm:30, hh:mm:45)
3. Starts a 15-second capture window
4. Decodes the received FT8
5. Transmits (if armed) at the start of the next boundary

This alignment is **automatic** — you don't configure slots. But **time accuracy is critical**:

- ± 500 ms error → can miss decodes or transmit off-slot
- ± 1 s error → very few decodes, transmit often off-time

- ± 2 s error or worse → FT8 doesn't work

6.9. Time Sources Summary

Source	Accuracy	Updates	Works Offline?
QMX GPS	~10 ms (auto-detected, tick phase-lock)	every 5 min	Yes (if QMX has GPS)
SNTP	± 10 ms	~1 hour	No
RTC	± 1 min	at boot	Yes (30–40 h)
Manual	± 1 sec	on-demand	Yes (until power cycle)
FT8-derived	offline fallback only	continuous	Yes

Next: Configure [Settings](#) or troubleshoot [Time Sync Problems](#).

The Tab5 needs accurate UTC for FT8 slot timing. Sources in priority order (highest first):

Source	When applied
SNTP (WiFi)	Always authoritative whenever WiFi is connected and has synced at least once — sets system clock, Tab5 RTC, and NVS
Tab5 RTC	RX8130CE supercap-backed (~30–40 h retention) — applied at boot before QMX or WiFi are available
QMX TM	Offline fallback only — applied when WiFi is down or has never synced (field/POTA with no WiFi)
FT8 signal timing	Sub-second correction from the decoded signal population's average timing, auto-applied continuously every slot while FT8 is decoding (damped, so a noisy single slot can't yank the clock) — deliberately tracks who you're actually trying to work, not absolute GPS/NTP truth. A manual one-shot version is also available via the Sync Time modal (see below)
Manual	Full HH:MM override in the Sync Time modal — for rare POTA sessions with neither WiFi nor QMX clock

Each accepted sync writes through to the RX8130CE so the clock persists across power-off. The Tab5 also polls τ M; every 5 minutes in the background to catch QMX GPS lock events.

For POTA / no-WiFi use: uncheck **WiFi initiated** in the settings drawer. Time comes from the QMX on USB connect (or the supercap RTC if the Tab5 was recently synced). FT8 slot timing will be accurate from either source.

FT8 time calibration modal

On the FT8 screen, tap **Filter** → **Sync Time** to open the time calibration modal. It shows three large boxes: **[HH] : [MM] : [SS]**.

- **HH / MM** — pre-filled from the current UTC clock. Tap either box to edit it with a numpad. Use this for rare POTA situations where neither WiFi nor the QMX clock is available.
 - **SS** — auto-syncs continuously from decoded FT8 signals. Each slot, every successfully decoded station contributes a timing sample; a robust outlier-rejecting average (median $\pm$ a tolerance window) across all of them sets the correction, so one bad decode can't throw off the reading. The box border flashes bright blue for ~30 ms each time a fresh measurement lands — a visual heartbeat that sync is active — and the hint below reads "**Flash: FT8 synced...**". A blue frame means it is actively tracking; tap SS to lock it.
 - **Apply** — if only SS was synced (HH and MM untouched), `time_sync_apply_correction_ms()` nudges the system clock by the measured sub-second offset and writes through to the RTC. If HH or MM was edited, `time_sync_set_manual()` sets the full time. The bottom bar shows **UTC(FT8)** after an FT8-derived correction, or **UTC(manual)** after a full manual set.
-

7. Reference

Gestures

Gesture	Where	Effect
Tap	Spectrum / waterfall	Tune to tapped frequency (snapped)
Touch + drag (hold ~250 ms first)	Spectrum / waterfall	Cyan cursor snaps grid-to-grid; tunes on release
Fast one-finger horizontal swipe	Spectrum / waterfall, any zoom	Pan/"stroll" the view; retunes to the new centre on release
Double-tap	Spectrum / waterfall	Reset zoom and pan to $\times 1.0$ / centred
Pinch (two fingers)	Spectrum / waterfall	Zoom $\times 1.0$ – $\times 24.0$
Two-finger drag	Spectrum / waterfall (zoomed)	Pan the zoomed window
Swipe → from left edge	Left edge strip	Toggle Panadapter ↔ FT8 screen
Swipe ← from right edge	Right edge strip	Open settings drawer
Tap right grip handle	Right edge	Open settings drawer (alternative)
Swipe →	Open drawer, or spectrum while drawer open	Close settings drawer
Swipe ↑ from bottom edge	Bottom edge strip	Open memory channel picker
Tap or swipe ↓	Top-bar item (Band/Mode/BW/Freq/Zoom)	Open that item's selector

Gesture	Where	Effect
Touch and hold ~250 ms	FT8 decode list row	Dim preview at ~80 ms; full selection at 250 ms (scroll locks, drag moves highlight, lift to confirm)
Quick swipe	FT8 decode list	Scroll the list normally

Bluetooth mouse

A Bluetooth mouse is the one pointer that works **while the QMX is plugged in**. A USB mouse cannot: the radio occupies the Tab5's only USB host, and sharing it through a hub does not work on this hardware — the ESP32-P4's USB host has no Transaction Translator, so every full- or low-speed device behind a hub is disabled. Bluetooth never touches that port, so the radio keeps its connection.

For anyone operating with cold or unsteady hands, that is the whole point: every menu, button and drawer control becomes a click instead of a precise tap on glass.

Setting it up — once:

1. Tick **Network** → **Bluetooth mouse** → **Enable (then pair the mouse)**.
2. **Restart the Tab5**. Bluetooth can only start after the link to the wireless co-processor is up, so the switch takes effect on the next boot. The confirmation toast says so.
3. Put the mouse in pairing mode and wait a few seconds. It connects on its own.

The pairing is stored and survives reboots *and* firmware updates — from then on the mouse reconnects by itself.

The Bluetooth symbol sits in the bottom bar just left of the WiFi indicator: dim grey when switched off, pale when on and looking, **blue** when a mouse is connected. The web UI mirrors it.

What works: moving the pointer, left click, and the scroll wheel — which scrolls whatever is under the pointer, so the decode list, the settings drawer and the manual all scroll.

The pointer disappears when the mouse sleeps. A Bluetooth mouse switches itself off after about half a minute of stillness to save its battery, and the pointer goes with it. It comes back the instant you move the mouse — reconnecting takes under a third of a second. That is the mouse looking after its own battery, not a fault.

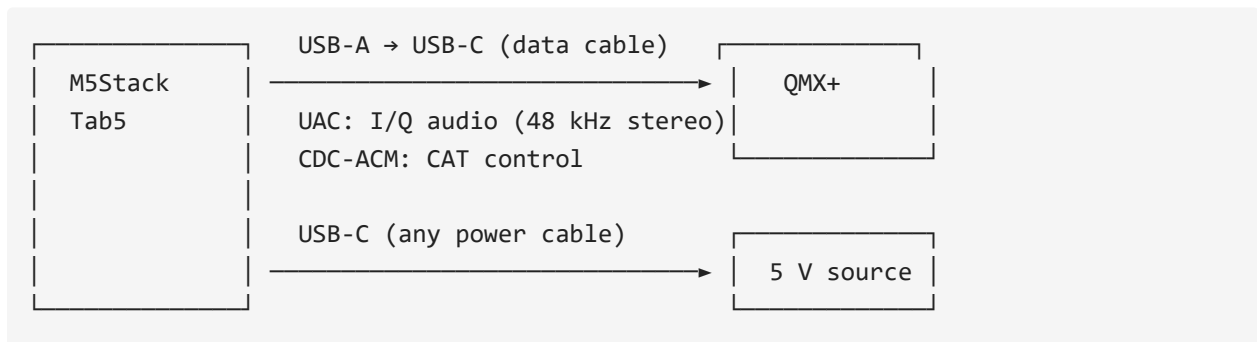
It costs about 5 KB of memory: the Bluetooth pools live in external RAM and the stack is sized for exactly one mouse, which is what makes it affordable on a board this tight. Off by default.

Per-unit IF calibration

The QMX's +12 kHz IF injection varies slightly between units. If signals appear consistently shifted left or right of where the QMX is actually tuned, open the settings drawer → **IF calibration** slider (± 100 Hz, persisted to NVS). Default 0. Reported by Ken KF0AYY, whose unit needed about -55 Hz to centre correctly.

Hardware

- **M5Stack Tab5** — ESP32-P4 v1.3 (ECO2), ST7121 or ST7123 5" 720×1280 MIPI-DSI touch display, 32 MB PSRAM, ESP32-C6 co-processor for WiFi
- **QRP Labs QMX or QMX+** — firmware 1.03.002 or newer (the 1.04 betas also work, and unlock AM mode + Antenna Tune)
- **USB-A → USB-C data cable** between Tab5 USB-A host port and QMX (full data, not charge-only)
- **USB-C power supply** for the Tab5 (5 V / 2 A or better, or internal battery)



What works without the QMX connected

Works without QMX	Needs QMX connected
UI, settings drawer, gestures	Spectrum + waterfall (no I/Q = flat line)
WiFi, web UI, screenshots	Top bar Band / Mode / BW
Callsign / grid / WiFi credentials	Tap-to-tune, mode popup (CAT writes)
Brightness, colour map, dB range	S-meter, FT8 decode/TX, QMX firmware readout

If the spectrum is flat and the top bar shows ---, that is almost always the radio not being seen over USB — which loops back to the cable (or the QMX being off / in flash mode).

Spectrum signal shifted / mirrored, tunable across the whole 48 kHz window

This means the QMX never confirmed IQ mode for the session — without it the radio streams plain (non-IQ) audio instead of a centred baseband, so the signal appears at the wrong place and slides across the full 48 kHz window as you tune. As of v0.19.3 the Tab5 retries the IQ-mode handshake automatically at connect (up to 4 attempts) and this resolves itself almost every time; if it still fails after all retries, a red banner appears across the top of the screen telling you so immediately, instead of leaving you to figure it out from a shifted waterfall. If you see the banner, power-cycle the QMX (forces a fresh handshake on reconnect) or check the QMX's own **System Config** → **IQ Mode** setting.

Reporting hardware issues

Near the top of the boot log you will see:

```
I (xxxx) bsp_info: === TAB5 BSP INFO ===
I (xxxx) bsp_info: chip:      ESP32-P4 rev v1.3
I (xxxx) bsp_info: psram:    30 MB
I (xxxx) bsp_info: panel:    ST7123 (inferred from touch)
I (xxxx) bsp_info: touch:    ST7123 @ 0x55
I (xxxx) bsp_info: heap:     230.5 kB internal free, 28.80 MB PSRAM free
I (xxxx) bsp_info: idf:      v5.4.4
I (xxxx) bsp_info: firmware: v0.21.0
I (xxxx) bsp_info: =====
```

When opening a hardware issue, paste this block — the `panel` and `touch` lines are the first thing needed to identify which Tab5 hardware revision you have.

Note on reset_reason: a deliberate reset-button force-off returns `panic/exception`, not `external-pin/power-on`. A genuine firmware crash always prints a `Guru Meditation` register + backtrace dump immediately *before* the reboot. No backtrace = abrupt power-off, not a crash.

Appendix — Technical Reference

The sections below are the remaining, more technical parts of the same project README (build instructions, internal design notes, roadmap) — included here so the links above resolve, rather than dead-ending. Skip ahead if you only want operating instructions.

Appendix A — Build from source

Requires **ESP-IDF v5.4.4** — pinned; do not upgrade. ESP32-P4 v1.3 silicon requires `CONFIG_ESP32P4_REV_MIN_0=y` and CPU capped at 360 MHz, both baked into `sdkconfig`.

```
# Activate the IDF environment, then:
idf.py build flash monitor
```

Or with the `qmx` PowerShell helper — add to your `$PROFILE` and adjust the COM port:

```
function qmx {
    param([string]$cmd = "fm")
    if (-not $env:IDF_PATH) { & C:\esp\v5.4.4\esp-idf\export.ps1 }
    switch ($cmd) {
        "b" { idf.py build }
        "f" { idf.py flash }
        "m" { python -m esp_idf_monitor -p COM3 build\qmx_panadapter.elf }
        "fm" { idf.py flash; python -m esp_idf_monitor -p COM3
            build\qmx_panadapter.elf }
        "bfm" { idf.py build flash; python -m esp_idf_monitor -p COM3
            build\qmx_panadapter.elf }
    }
}
```

Exit monitor: `Ctrl+T` then `Ctrl+X`.

Appendix B — Under the hood

I/Q balance correction

The QMX presents I/Q audio with a small but measurable amplitude imbalance and quadrature error between channels. Without correction, every signal produces a mirror image across the centre frequency (~ 30 dB weaker), cluttering the waterfall on a busy band.

A blind adaptive Gram-Schmidt orthogonaliser runs sample-by-sample in the audio pipeline before the FFT. It maintains running estimates of:

- **DC offset** on each channel ($\tau = 1$ s)
- **Power** in I and Q ($\tau = 200$ ms)
- **Cross-product** I·Q ($\tau = 1$ s) — non-zero cross-product means the channels are not orthogonal

Correction per sample:

```
i_out = i
q_out = (q - K_phi · i) × K_amp
```

No calibration step needed; the estimator converges on ambient band noise within a few seconds of any signal. A two-speed startup runs all alphas at $8\times$ for the first 2 s of real signal after each reset (effective convergence ~ 125 ms), then drops to steady-state. Toggle in the settings drawer; re-enabling resets the estimator so it reconverges from a clean state.

DSP pipeline

- **FFT**: 1024-pt complex, Blackman-Harris window. esp-dsp ANSI fallback is used (the PIE/vector version crashes under sustained WebSocket load on this silicon).
- **IF offset**: The QMX presents I/Q at +12 kHz; spectrum, waterfall, and S-meter all shift bin selection by $n_{\text{bins}}/4$ so the VFO signal appears at the visual centre.
- **DC blocker**: one-pole IIR on the I/Q stream before FFT.
- **Spectrum smoothing**: per-bin EMA ($\alpha = 0.4$ default, adjustable).
- **dBm calibration**: `DSP_DB_CALIBRATION_OFFSET` = -148.0 dB measured on dummy load; noise floor reads -130 dBm; $S9 = -73$ dBm.
- **Waterfall scroll**: 1280×824 double-height canvas (~ 130 μs /tick vs ~ 92 ms with memmove).

- **Audio task:** polling on core 0 with a drain loop. Event-driven reads caused noise-floor pumping (~13 s cycle) from truncated UAC chunks; this architecture eliminates it.

Quirks and trade-offs

PI4IO expander must be initialised before display bring-up. The Tab5's PI4IO I/O expander holds `LCD_RST` and `TP_RST` low at chip power-on. Without explicit init, on a true cold boot the panel never comes out of reset and the DSI FIFO hangs. Soft resets mask this because the expander retains state across ESP32 resets. `display_init` calls `bsp_i2c_init()` + `bsp_io_expander_pi4ioe_init()` first, then waits 120 ms.

Patched components in `components/.espressif__usb_host_uac/` has `create_background_task = true` — required for UAC and CDC-ACM to coexist on the same USB host. `espressif__esp_lcd_touch_st7123/` makes `FW_VERSION_REG` the only mandatory register read (ST7121 NACKs the others and also adds a `max_touches > 10` bounds clamp). Do not replace either with the registry version without re-applying the patches.

LVGL software rotation (~50% FPS cost). The panel is natively portrait; landscape is achieved via `lv_display_set_rotation(LV_DISPLAY_ROTATION_90)`. Every flush goes through `rotate90_rgb565`. ~13 fps landscape vs ~22 fps portrait — acceptable for a panadapter. PPA hardware rotation conflicts with the USB host stack over DW-GDMA channels and silently kills UAC + CDC-ACM; do not set `CONFIG_LVGL_PORT_ENABLE_PPA=y`. A full native-landscape rewrite would recover the lost FPS but isn't planned — accepted as a permanent trade-off.

IDLE watchdog disabled. The LVGL rotation pipeline keeps CPU0 busy past the default watchdog window. `CONFIG_ESP_TASK_WDT_CHECK_IDLE_TASK_CPU0/CPU1` are off; the app-task watchdog (30 s) is still active.

Cross-thread CAT writes must go through the poll task. Writing CAT commands directly from the LVGL thread races the FA/MD/FW poll on the same CDC pipe — commands interleave and the QMX returns ?;. Pattern: stash the request in a `volatile` and let `poll_task` drain it on its next cycle. See `s_pending_ssb_bw / cat_request_ssb_bandwidth()` in `cat.c`.

SSB filter bandwidth needs three coordinated writes. `MMSSB|Filter RX=<hz>;` commits the value (persists, shows in QMX menu); `MMSSB|Bandwidth=<hz>;` applies it live; FW; polling must be suspended while the width is pinned because reading the filter makes the QMX revert it. Dead ends: `FW<nnnn>;` CAT set returns ?;; re-asserting the same mode digit does not reload the filter; `Bandwidth` write alone reverts on the next poll.

HTTPS needs mbedtls allocating from PSRAM, not internal RAM. The QRZ/eQSL upload features (v0.16.2) are this firmware's first-ever outbound HTTPS connections — SNTP, the only prior network client, is UDP. With the default

`CONFIG_MBEDTLS_MEM_ALLOC_MODE=MBEDTLS_INTERNAL_MEM_ALLOC`, the TLS handshake's 16 KB+ buffers competed for the ~200 KB internal DRAM already under pressure from USB host/audio/FFT/LVGL and every connection failed with `ESP_ERR_HTTP_CONNECT`. Fixed by switching to `MBEDTLS_EXTERNAL_MEM_ALLOC` in `sdkconfig`, which moves those buffers into the 28 MB of free PSRAM instead.

Project layout

main/	
main.c	app_main, task launch, orchestration
display/display.c	BSP bring-up (PI4IO + LCD + touch)
ui/ui.c	LVGL widgets, touch handler, canvases
ui/ft8_screen_view.c	FT8 decode list, touch-drag row selection
ui/ft8_tx_modal.c	TX confirmation modal
cat/cat.c	USB CDC-ACM + Kenwood CAT
audio/audio.c	USB UAC + ring buffer producer
dsp/dsp.c	FFT, spectrum mutex, DC blocker
dsp/iq_balance.c	Gram-Schmidt I/Q correction
ft8_tx.c	FT8 TX engine (build/arm/run/abort)
ft8_test.c	FT8 slot loop (RX decode / TX burst)
ft8_qso.c	Auto QSO state machine
ft8_sim.c	FT8 simulation mode: phantom-station practice QSOs
ft8_status.c	Mutex-protected FT8 status string
adif/adif_log.c	ADIF QSO logging
adif/qrz_upload.c	QRZ Logbook API upload (one record per request)
adif/eqsl_upload.c	eQSL.cc upload (batched, multiple records per request)
rtc/rtc.c	RX8130CE supercap RTC driver
time_sync/time_sync.c	Time sync orchestrator
render/render.c	30 Hz render task, EMA smoothing
render/render_waterfall.c	Waterfall scroll (double-height canvas)
screenshot/screenshot.c	RGB565 framebuffer capture for /ss.bmp
storage/settings.c	NVS-backed settings with debounced flush
wifi/wifi.c	C6 co-processor WiFi + SNTP
net/webserver.c	HTTP server + WebSocket
util/fps.c	FPS counter
util/diag_log.c	Diagnostic log ring buffer (vprintf hook)

Appendix C — Roadmap

The full per-version changelog — every release from v0.1.0 onward — lives in [docs/version-history.md](#). This section tracks only what's planned next.

Next up

v1.7.0 is here — a mouse, the phone spots that were missing, and knowing who hears you. A Bluetooth mouse drives the Tab5 with the QMX still plugged in; DX cluster spots bring the SSB activity RBN cannot see; activation mode stamps and counts your POTA/SOTA contacts; SWR protection stops a transmission going into a bad antenna; and "who is hearing me" asks PSK Reporter which receivers copied your call. Next on the bench:

- **Web-UI audio streaming.** Listen to the receiver in any browser on your LAN — demodulated on the Tab5, no PC. Already working in development; held back for quality tuning and an overnight streaming soak. Server mode (screen off, device just serves) rides along.
- **CW page.** Canned-message CW TX memories first; decoded-CW display after (the QMX decodes internally — mirroring it over CAT looks cheap).
- **Binaural CW audio.** Asked for by Roy KI0ER, and shaped by Don N2VGU and Michael KZ4LY: a stereo sound stage so two stations a few tens of hertz apart land in different places in your head, with the **stage width a setting** rather than a fixed angle. The DSP is small — the Tab5 already receives I and Q separately — but it needs the Tab5's own audio output path, which is the same rework the CW page waits on.
- **Tab5 audio output rework.** The blocker under both of the above: the output task must not run at all in FT8/FT4 (Michael KZ4LY's suggestion), since merely existing at a higher priority than the FFT consumer cost decode yield.

Longer term

- **CW decoder.** Goertzel-based, text scrolling under the spectrum. The QMX already does this internally — question is whether to mirror its output via CAT or run a parallel decoder on the Tab5.
- **Tab5 speaker / headphone audio.** Demodulated CW/SSB passband audio out of the Tab5's own jack, so the operator can monitor without the QMX's audio path.
- **Extended waterfall history.** PSRAM has room for several minutes of scrollbar; two-finger drag to scrub through history.
- **QMX (small) support.** Same UI, different USB endpoint config and band table.
- **JS8 / RTTY modes.** See [docs/js8-feasibility.md](#) and [docs/rtty-feasibility.md](#).

- **DSP polish.** Noise reduction, auto-notch.
-

Appendix D — Related projects

- [DX-FT8](#) by Barb (WB2CBA) — open-hardware FT8 tablet transceiver; an inspiring reference for a similar use-case
 - [qrp_companion](#) by Zhenxing Han (N6HAN) — Tab5 companion for QMX with audio + CAT; source of the polling audio task pattern and battery readout approach
 - [ft8_lib](#) by Karlis Goba — FT8 encoder/decoder vendored as `components/ft8_lib`
-

Glossary

Common terms and acronyms used in this guide:

Term	Meaning
CAT	Computer-Aided Transceiver — radio control protocol (Kenwood-style commands via serial/USB)
CDC-ACM	Communications Device Class / Abstract Control Model — USB standard for serial ports
CQ	General call to any station (not directed at anyone specific)
CW	Continuous Wave — Morse code mode
DSP	Digital Signal Processing — mathematical signal analysis and filtering
FFT	Fast Fourier Transform — algorithm to convert time-domain audio into frequency spectrum
FT8 / FT4	Digital modes for weak-signal HF communication (15-second vs 7.5-second slots). Both fully supported (FT4 re-enabled in v0.21.0).
GPIO	General-Purpose Input/Output — microcontroller pins for digital signals
I2C / SPI	Serial communication protocols for connecting peripherals (sensors, displays, etc.)
IQ	In-phase / Quadrature — stereo representation of RF signals (real + imaginary parts)
LVGL	Light and Versatile Graphics Library — open-source embedded UI toolkit used for the display
NVS	Non-Volatile Storage — persistent memory on the ESP32 (survives power cycles)
PSRAM	Pseudo-SRAM — extra RAM on the Tab5 (used for large buffers like waterfall history)
QMX / QMX+	QRP Labs HF transceiver — the radio this panadapter controls and receives audio from
QSO	Radio contact / conversation between two stations

Term	Meaning
RTC	Real-Time Clock — battery-backed timer on the Tab5 (keeps time during power-off)
SNTP	Simple Network Time Protocol — synchronizes system clock via WiFi/internet
SWR	Standing Wave Ratio — antenna impedance matching metric (1.0 = perfect)
TX / RX	Transmit / Receive — keying the radio and listening
UAC	USB Audio Class — standard for streaming audio over USB
USB	Universal Serial Bus — physical connector and protocol (carries both audio and CAT commands)
UTC	Coordinated Universal Time — timezone-independent time standard for FT8 slot alignment
VFO	Variable Frequency Oscillator — the radio's tuning dial / frequency setting

Contributing

This is a solo project — all coding is done by the author (OZ1LAV) at his own pace, and **pull requests are not being accepted right now**. Bug reports, feature requests, and field reports are very welcome, though, via [GitHub Issues](#) or the [QRPLabs Groups.io thread](#). See [CONTRIBUTING.md](#) for details.

Appendix E — License

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